

Prague University of Economics and Business

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**Implementation of sustainable marketing methods
within the context of the Czech market**

BACHELOR THESIS

Study programme: Multimedia in the Economic Practice

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DECLARATION OF AUTHENTICITY

I hereby declare that the bachelor's thesis: "Implementation of sustainable marketing methods within the context of the Czech market" is my own work, utilizing the sources and literature referenced within the thesis.

In Prague, May 2024

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ABSTRACT

Escalating climate change, lack of waste regulation, social issues and clothing waste pollution pose grave threats to our planet, people, and future. This crisis impacts everyone, demanding action across all sectors and industries. This bachelor thesis presents aspects in which marketers can integrate more sustainable and responsible actions into their strategies and evaluates the operational aspects of the Czech brand with sustainability goals – Freshlabels. To assess the effectiveness of Freshlabels' sustainability efforts, this thesis analyses the brand's behaviour using the 'Revisiting the 7 Ps through Responsible Sustainable Marketing Lens' framework. Additionally, the target customer group's perspective is incorporated through interviews. In conclusion the research revealed customers and companies focus predominantly on sustainability of the sold product rather than the comprehensive sustainable marketing practises. Interviews further reveal that while Freshlabels actively promotes its commitment to sustainable fashion within the Czech Republic, their primary emphasis remains on ensuring the profitability and longevity of the company. True sustainable marketing principles advocate for placing environmental and social concerns on par with profit for an optimal outcome.

KEYWORDS

sustainability, sustainable marketing, marketing through sustainable lens, fashion industry, greenwashing, transparency.

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INTRODUCTION

The planet is dying. 2023 was the warmest year recorded and 4 months into 2024 does not look much better. (NOAA, 2024) Climate change and no waste regulation are causing extreme weather conditions we are starting to witness regularly worldwide, the mountains of hardly worn clothing piling up in deserts, oceans and forests, and the consequential rising mental health issues are current problems that primarily affect younger generations. (Randle & Eyre, 2023)

Witnessing environmental catastrophes firsthand or through news and social media takes a significant toll on mental well-being, potentially leading to conditions such as post-traumatic stress disorder, anxiety, depression, and substance abuse. The growing severity of hurricanes, heat, fires, floods is impossible to ignore. A 2018 study found a strong link between negative environmental news and emotional distress in young adults (18-34). (Pearson, 2024) Many young people grapple with daily anxiety about the state of our planet and the daunting reality of a potentially worsening future. The potential for change exists within every profession. From our daily habits to larger-scale initiatives, opportunities for improvement abound. Only through collective action, where each individual recognizes their impact on the environment and acts accordingly, humanity can at least hope for the planet to heal in some way.

Marketing affects billions of people in their consumers behaviour, job opportunities and decisions, therefore, the potential it represents to make a meaningful change is enormous. By integrating environmental considerations into brand strategy, communication channels, stakeholder relations, and product development, marketing can become a powerful force for sustainability. (Carvill & Butler, 2024) Many current marketing metrics and success measures prioritize short-term gains and profit maximization, often at a significant cost. This relentless pursuit can fuel unsustainable consumption habits, mountains of waste, and a disconnect from the environmental consequences. While driving sales and brand awareness remain core marketing objectives, these goals should not come at the expense of transparency. Deliberately obfuscating the climate impact of companies regarding waste production, child labour, energy consumption etc. is not only unethical, but ultimately shortsighted. True progress demands a shift towards marketing strategies that promote responsible consumption and environmental awareness, even if it means challenging traditional notions of profit.

The demand for more sustainable business practices is not just driven by responsible and conscious consumers; it is also being fuelled by a workforce seeking purpose. For young professionals, the ability to make a meaningful impact through their work is a major factor when choosing an employer. (The Stepsone group, 2023)

This thesis examines sustainable practices that companies can integrate into their operations. It then analyses how a well-known fashion brand is adapting to these practices and evaluates the true extent of their sustainability efforts.

The theoretical part of my bachelor thesis presents an overview of sustainability; history, key practises, and concepts. This foundation is crucial for marketers who want to drive positive change. Sustainability is a wide-ranging topic, encompassing everything from environmental science and social responsibility to international politics and economic innovation. While the thesis cannot cover everything, this thesis will focus on the aspects most relevant to marketers pursuing environmentally conscious strategies.

The next chapter dives into the ideas presented in "Can Marketing Save the Planet?" by Michelle Carvill and Gemma Butler. This book inspires and empowers marketers by highlighting practical changes they can implement. It also provides valuable resources for self-education and finding inspiration. Finally, the last chapter targets the business considerations behind adopting sustainable practices and implementing responsible changes within companies.

The practical part begins with analysis of a leading Czech sustainable fashion company's approach to sustainable and transparent practices, focusing primarily on their approach to marketing. The results then lead to comparison of the company's approach with customers' views of the company's strategy. The information for practical part is gathered from an interview with Freshlabels CEO Ladislav Žižka, Freshlabels website and their blog. The customer's view was assessed based on eight qualitative interviews with customers who value sustainability and care about the environmental and social impact of their shopping. Four of which have already shopped at Freshlabels and four who have not. The conclusion presents specific findings and insights based on the theoretical and practical analysis conducted.

1 THEORETICAL PART

This part of bachelor thesis is dedicated to the background of sustainability for better understanding of the topic. It covers the evolution of sustainability and reasons why it is essential to apply such practices in today's world. It also covers the basis of sustainable marketing. The main principles and reasons behind it and also exploring the motives for companies to switch into more ethically oriented production and functioning.

1.1 SUSTAINABILITY

In today's world, sustainability is one of the most frequently used terms in the public sphere. Whether it concerns the environment, business, fashion, or construction, there is a demand for sustainability everywhere. In this chapter, the thesis addresses what sustainability is and how the trend of sustainability emerged. This chapter attempts to clarify why sustainability is such a popular and crucial topic for society in the 21st century.

1.1.1 Historical development of sustainability

We can understand sustainability as an idea. Some ideas are so widely accepted that they are eventually perceived to be necessary or true. And just like other big revolutionary ideas its development or discovery was not linear. (Pfister, Thomas, 2016)

As many other brilliant ideas and philosophies also the origins of sustainability can be found already in ancient Rome. Even though the Romans did not think about the global scale and impact of their actions they saw the potential and benefit in using less exploitative farming techniques. This points to a relationship between humans and environment characterised by a need to care for the latter. (Pfister, Thomas, 2016). In other words, ancient Romans knew their behaviour towards the environment, the soil, their farms will affect how the environment changes in the future years, and they put earnest effort in farming the most efficient way. People at that time have not yet used the word "sustainable." The idea came first. Naming the idea or a process came much later.

Both "sustainable and "sustainability" derive from the Latin sustinere, which combines the word sub (up from below) and tenere (to hold), and means to "maintain," "sustain," "endure," or, perhaps most poignantly, "to restrain."

(Caradonna, Jeremy L., 2014, p.7)

After various transformations, the word passed to English as a verb „to sustain “. (Caradonna, Jeremy L., 2014,)

The word "sustainability" first occurred in 1713 in forestry. (Wiersum, 1995) Before the common use of fossil fuels, many global societies heavily depended on trees for fuel and various necessities. Society was at risk of facing serious problems as deforestation became a pressing concern. It was Hans Carl von Carlowitz who first stressed the importance of never harvesting more than the forest produces in the new growth and never harvesting more than what is the ultimate need. He reflected on timber shortages in his work *Sylvicultura Oeconomica* or the Instructions for Wild Tree Cultivation and set the example for a new way of managing mining. (The Environment & Society Portal)

Many adopted his ideology, and most of his fundamental ideas about deforestation are still taught in schools today, but even that did not prevent the continued deforestation of Europe. During the 17th century, colonial powers like England, France, the Netherlands, Portugal, and others seized control of numerous islands and distant regions to access resources. Moving into the middle and late 18th century, certain bureaucrats began to acknowledge that deforestation had noticeable effects on local climates, making them drier and warmer. In areas that had been extensively cleared of greenery, there was a significant decrease in rainfall. These Europeans were among the earliest to grasp the idea that human activities could indeed influence climate change. In a way, it is simpler to identify environmental damage and its effects on isolated tropical islands, compared to recognizing these issues back in their own homelands. (Caradonna, Jeremy L., 2014,)

With the onset of the Industrial Revolution, these concerns escalated. It was not quite clear back then that human activities—the same ones responsible for the 'progress' of humankind—might eventually cause an ecological catastrophe. Yet even during the revolution, there were loud voices of protest against the industries causing pollution, poverty, ghettoization, child labour, and living conditions not worthy of human dignity (Caradonna, Jeremy L., 2014,)

It is worth noting, too, that the population of the world only began to take off during the Industrial Revolution as well as the carbon dioxide emissions as depicted in Figure 1.

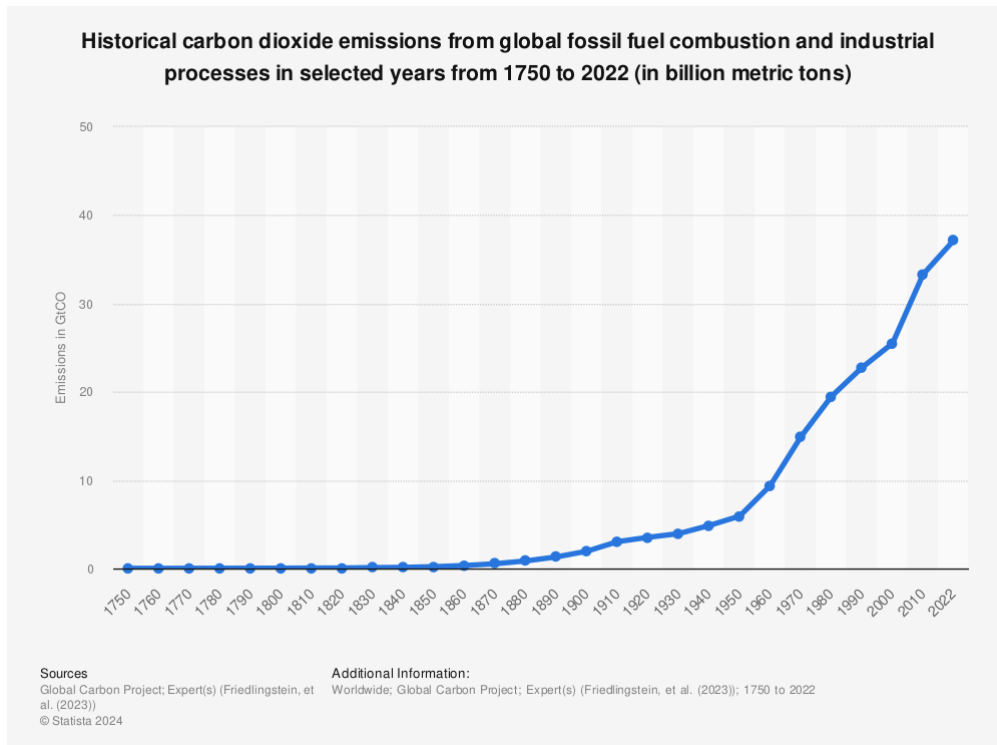


Figure 1: Global Carbon Project. (November 6, 2023). Historical carbon dioxide emissions from global fossil fuel combustion and industrial processes in selected years from 1750 to 2022 (in billion metric tons) [Graph]. In Statista. Retrieved April 16, 2024, from <https://www-statista-com.zdroje.vse.cz/statistics/264699/worldwide-co2-emissions/>

In summary, the eighteenth century laid the groundwork for a prolonged conflict concerning the social, economic, and environmental consequences of economic growth, a conflict that would unfold over the course of the nineteenth century and beyond. In the 18th century various scientists and economists started raising concerns about the limited nature of natural resources, especially combined with the population growth. (Caradonna, Jeremy L., 2014,)

However, sustainability entered widespread awareness only in the early 1970s. Greenpeace, founded in 1971, commenced its operations with a mission to combat environmental damage through civil protests and nonviolent interference. Simultaneously, the United Nations embraced the concept of sustainable development and started organizing various conferences and programs on the topic of sustainability. In 1972, in a significant development, the Club of Rome published "The Limits to Growth," a report predicting dire consequences if population growth was not restricted. This influential publication called for the establishment of a global equilibrium to address the challenges outlined. (Serrat, 2012)

A pivotal moment in capturing the attention of global policymakers occurred with the release of the Brundtland Report by the United Nations in 1987. This report embraced the concept of sustainability, granting it widespread acknowledgment worldwide. (Brundtland, 1987) It brings to light the term sustainable development and highlights the need of long-term strategies to manage natural resources. With over half a million copies sold worldwide by 1989 it was this

report which introduced the term sustainability into the language of international politics and business. (Gerasimova, 2017)

The organization Natural Step was founded a year later by Karl-Henrik Robert to create and promote a shared language with a set of sustainability principles. It was one of the first organizations which focused on building or rebuilding whole organisations to create as they call it future-fit society. It operates for more than 30 years and through various education programs and advisory services helps companies to find value in sustainability and set an example for others. (THE NATURAL STEP, 2020)

By the 1990s, sustainability principles were applied across various sectors, shaping economic analyses, planning commissions, and influencing domains like education, agriculture, and transportation. The media embraced sustainability as a buzzword associated with green values. (Caradonna, Jeremy L., 2014,) The sustainability movement has swiftly moved from the margins to the mainstream, gaining widespread acceptance in recent years. In today's world everybody knows what sustainability means. It even got to the point where it is overwhelming, and it is almost impossible to keep up with all the emerging sustainability trends and forms.

In conclusion, the history of sustainability goes back, starting with the ancient nations caring for the land where they were simply aware of the natures processes and transformed their ways accordingly. The word "sustainability" came about in 1713, and the perception of it changed throughout the years. By the 1970s and 1980s, people started paying more attention to the environment and its effects on our lives and well-being. In 1987 the Brundtland Report by the United Nations introduced to the broad public the connection between environmental, social, and economic issues and really started the call for global cooperation to address challenges and achieve a balanced and sustainable future. Afterwards sustainability became a globally known topic and now it is one of the biggest trends and buzz words used in modern countries.

1.1.2 Definition and concepts of sustainability

In 1987, the Brundtland Commission's report outlined sustainability with three equally important components, all beginning with the letter 'e' in English: environment, economy, and equity. The idea is that for a business to be sustainable, we need to protect the environment, support economic growth, and make sure everyone gets a fair share. The key point is that success in one area should not harm the others. It rejects the belief that we must choose between making money, taking care of the environment, or being fair. Sustainability works best when we can do all three – grow economically, improve the environment, and be fair to everyone. (Portney, 2015). It became the standard in defining sustainable development.

In the mid-1990s, there were over one hundred definitions of sustainability, creating confusion and making the term almost meaningless. This confusion distracts from the urgent need to address ongoing environmental problems. Nevertheless, there are four leading sustainability business frameworks: The Triple Bottom Line, The natural Step, The Ecological Footprint and Graedel and Klee's Sustainable Emissions and Resource Usage. (Marshall, Toffel, 2004)

1.1.2.1 The Triple Bottom Line

The concept suggests that a company can be operated in a manner that not only generates profit but also enhances the quality of people's lives and contributes to the well-being of the planet. This concept which was introduced by John Elkington continues the message of Burtland report stressing the importance of shared focused between people, planet, and profit. In the past, companies mainly focused on profiting and growing. Now, leaders with a purpose are realizing they can use their businesses to make a positive impact without hurting financial performance. In fact, adopting sustainability initiatives has been shown to contribute to business success. Eventually sustainable strategies might even be a necessity for companies to profit. (Miller, 2020)

1.1.2.2 The Natural Step

The Natural Steo defines sustainable society or business based on four factors. Firstly, there is a strategic replacement of fossil fuels and minerals or any non-renewable natural resources. Secondly, the production of substances such as chemicals is transitioning towards the use of natural or easily degradable compounds ensuring their efficient use and releasing them at a pace that nature can balance. Thirdly, it focuses on local resources and local eco-systems, and motivating each to use them effectively, in order to balance the reduction of Earth's natural cycles and biodiversity. Lastly t is crucial to ensure that people can fulfil their requirements and basic needs and does not face consequences of harmful economic or political behaviour. (SVID, 2018) Building on the principles outlined by The Natural Step, it is clear the path to a sustainable society or business requires systemic changes across all sectors and levels of society. This transition not only requires technological innovation and the adoption of green practices but also a fundamental shift in how we perceive our relationship with the environment.

1.1.2.3 The Ecological Footprint

In 1990, Mathis Wackernagel and William Rees introduced the Ecological Footprint© at the University of British Columbia. Today, it is extensively employed by scientists, businesses, governments, individuals, and institutions. Ecological Footprint accounting evaluates the use

and availability of natural resources. It evaluates the ecological materials needed by a specific population or product and compares it with the assets it generates to handle its waste, particularly carbon emissions. (Ecological Footprint, n.d.)

1.1.2.4 Graedel and Klee's Sustainable Emissions and Resource Usage

Graedel and Klee suggest a four-step approach to establish a sustainable resource usage rate. Involving calculating available supplies, allocating consumption over time, accounting for recycling and existing stockpiles, and comparing it to current usage rates. These processes highlight the importance of specifying a time scale and suggest that certain rates of non-renewable resource consumption can be sustainable, as long as substitutes are identified to meet future needs. The main revolutionary idea of this approach is the importance of specifying substitutes to satisfy the needs of future generations. (Marshall, Toffel, 2004)

Being 100% sustainable - meaning generating no waste and only using as much energy and resources as we can replace or take from sustainable sources - is practically unattainable. Very few companies or communities achieve this. Sustainability in business usually refers to a company's strategy and actions aimed at reducing the negative environmental and social impacts resulting from its operations. (IBM) Therefore, in this work, we will consider sustainability as a practice that considers its impact on the environment, the supply chain, waste generation, and the working conditions of people, treating these factors with the same importance as profit.

1.2 SUSTAINABILITY IN MARKETING

Marketing is about creating profit. That generally means making customers buy more product and spend more money. On the other hand, sustainability motivates people not to live the consumer lifestyle and focus more on what is good for the ecosystem. It highlights the importance of using what we already have rather than buying more. However, even with the fields so distinctive from one another new opportunities are emerging where marketing aligns with sustainability goals. Sustainable marketing aims to balance profit with ecological responsibility, promoting products and practices that meet consumer needs while minimizing environmental impact.

Most people perceive sustainable marketing as marketing sustainable products, information, or business. Sustainable marketing goes beyond promoting eco-friendly products; it involves a purpose-driven approach to guide businesses and society toward sustainability. Simply changing what we buy is insufficient for addressing complex challenges. The sector must embrace a broader transformation, taking accountability for its impacts and influencing awareness, aspiration, adoption, and action for long-term wellbeing. Sustainable marketing

takes accountability of the waste it produces and the ways it operates and tries to change that in alignment with sustainable practises. (Thompson, 2023)

Business and marketing are two inseparable concepts. For a business, creating a customer is the key to success and a necessity. Marketing is responsible for this process. Its purpose is to identify potential customers, analyse their needs, behaviours, likes, and dislikes. Based on marketing research, a business can operate successfully by providing products that will sell. Consequently, determining how to sell them is also a mission for marketing. This includes deciding on the price point, choosing appropriate channels, and formulating communication and branding strategies. Traditionally, the success of marketing has been defined by satisfied customers and a profiting company, in other words, a win-win situation. However, in this scenario, crucial elements have long been overlooked, namely the environment and the workers. (Fuller, 1999)

The majority of businesses are aware of the growing pressure for sustainability, which often pushes them towards engaging in greenwashing. Greenwashing is the deceptive practice of conveying false or misleading information about a company's products' environmental friendliness. It involves making unsubstantiated claims to trick consumers into believing that the products have a greater positive impact on the environment than they actually do. Additionally, greenwashing may occur when a company emphasizes sustainable aspects of a product to divert attention from its involvement in environmentally damaging practices. This deceptive tactic often involves the use of environmental imagery, misleading labels, and concealing trade-offs. Essentially, greenwashing is akin to "whitewashing," where false information is used to hide wrongdoing or make a situation seem less negative than it truly is. (Hayen, 2024)

1.2.1 Definition and principles of sustainable marketing

When producing a product, naturally it begins by gathering resources to produce and market the product. Such practice leads to enormous eco-costs in the form of wastes, follow-on pollution, and damage to ecosystems when done globally. The opportunity lies in reshaping product systems to achieve "zero-waste, zero-discharge" outcomes, presenting a logical solution to mitigate ecological impact while still delivering value to customers. The sustainable marketing focuses on doing exactly that. Sustainable marketing can be understood by the following definition.

The process of planning, implementing, and controlling the development, pricing, promotion, and distribution of products in a manner that satisfies the following three criteria:

1) customer needs are met

- 2) *organizational goals are attained*
- 3) *the process is compatible with ecosystems.*

(Fuller, 1999, p.4)

Donald A. Fuller, author of the book *Sustainable marketing*, pioneer in this field and sustainability advocate is one of the first marketers who started redirecting the field and urging the change in approach to business. His focus was mainly on the ecosystem. He highlighted the essential role which marketing has in creating sustainable future, circular economy and saving the environment. Other authors follow him, building primarily on his reflections but generally expand the impact they can influence. Another aspect they pay great attention to includes working conditions, fair wages, and factors ensuring humane treatment of workers, which Fuller had not mentioned in 1999.

Many of the green methods now are grounded on the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). (Carvill & Butler, 2024) After years of scientific and social research, the SDGs offer a plan for life on Earth designed to eliminate poverty, enhance health and education, decrease inequality, and stimulate economic growth. They include plans to address climate change and protect our oceans and forests. It is accurate to state that the UN Sustainable Development Goals regard Earth as a crucial participant. Moreover, the SDGs are globally recognized as a unified framework, and we can surely describe them as a comprehensive and complete overview of points that need to be addressed. Within the sustainable development are following points: No poverty, Zero hunger, Good health and well-being, Quality education, Gender equality, Clean water and sanitation, Affordable and clean energy, Decent work and economic growth, Industry innovation and infrastructure, Reduced inequalities, Sustainable cities and communities, Responsible consumption and production, Climate action, Life below water, Life on land, Peace, Justice and strong institutions, Partnerships for the goals. (United Nations, n.d.)

The SDGs are designed to be applicable to nations, governments, entire industries, the private sector, and individuals alike. Nonetheless, many argue that the 17 SDGs are simply too comprehensive for a single company to actively address. It is crucial for companies, when considering a sustainable approach to production, to identify which of the 17 SDGs they can impact and subsequently implement suitable solutions within their strategies. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

For marketing purposes, Carvil and Butler have designed a new framework: The 7 Ps of Marketing through a Sustainable Lens as illustrated in Figure 2. The sustainable marketing adds new dimensions to the well-known strategy tool Marketing mix (7 Ps theory). The advantage is that they reflect a concept that is already in use and pose additional questions that make it easier for companies to answer. The 7 Ps being Product, Place, Price, Promotion, People,

Process, Physical Evidence. This is a unique tool through which marketers can evaluate each stage of the company they can affect and act accordingly to their sustainable goals. Additionally, these are also factors to analyse when deciding whether the company makes valuable changes or not. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

Revisiting the 7 P's through a Responsible Sustainable Marketing Lens

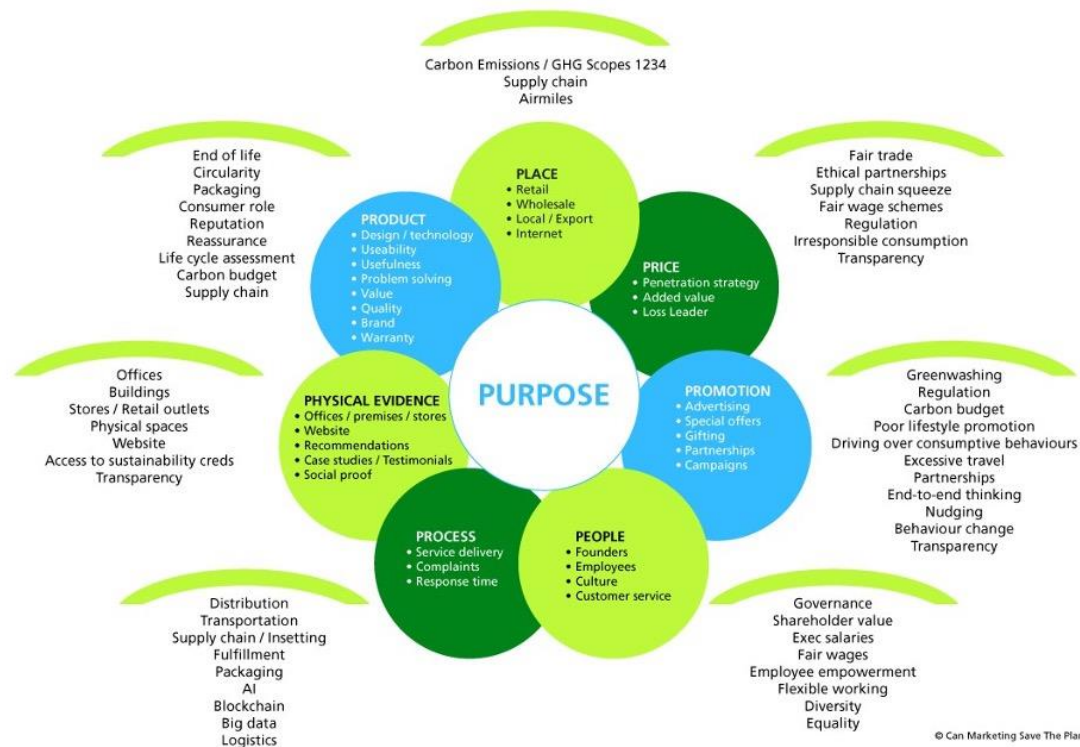


Figure 2: 7 P's through a Responsible Marketing Lens, Carvill, M., & Butler, G. (2024). *Can Marketing Save the Planet?* (1st ed.). Bloomsbury Publishing. <https://www.perlego.com/book/4305260/can-marketing-save-the-planet-101-practical-ways-to-use-sustainable-marketing-as-a-force-for-good-pdf>

1.2.1.1 Product

The Product System Life Cycle (PSLC) outlines the expanded scope of decisions marketers need to make in response to environmental concerns related to consumption. (Fuller, 1999) Regardless of whether it involves physical product or a service, adopting a sustainable mindset can greatly enhance the value of company's offerings. Creating a product which is consciously and ethically made, packed and distributed is what most customers look for in sustainable business, making it one of the most fundamental factors. Assessing and taking responsibility for company's product life cycles and understanding how they are used and where they go once purchased, should be a primary focus for marketers.

The primary question is whether the product adds value. When developing a sustainable product, it must serve a purpose; otherwise, it contributes to waste and supports consumerism,

as is often the case. Is it a quality product beneficial for customers, preferably one that lasts long and can be reused?

Other relevant aspect of the production is used materials and resource consumption. Nowadays there are so many possibilities to select earth friendly materials. Manufacturing can implement many great innovations, innovative or alternative materials, and processes to reduce the environmental footprint of various industries. Using renewable resources, sustainable manufacturing techniques or recycled materials all can make an immense difference. It is vital to evaluate how to make the development of a product more sustainable and to examine whether there is a more environmentally friendly source for each resource used. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

The manufacturing of a product itself is likewise a topic to focus at. Sustainable manufacturing involves producing goods using financially viable methods that minimize adverse environmental effects while conserving energy and natural resources. (U.S. Environmental Protection Agency, n.d.) In times of climate and economic challenges, innovation is essential for progress. Businesses have the opportunity to examine and enhance every aspect of their value chain, starting from the production of their product, essentially how it is made, by who and how big of an impact it has on eco-systems. Among universally applied practices are, for example, improving power efficiency, reducing water usage, replacing materials with sustainable alternatives. To illustrate: in fashion industry the global average water footprint of cotton fabric is 10,000 litres per kilogram. This translates to approximately 2,500 litres for a single cotton shirt weighing 250 grams and 8,000 litres for a pair of jeans weighing eight hundred grams. (Water Footprint Network, n.d.) Fashion brands can reduce water usage in production by adopting sustainable practices, including low water dyeing techniques and optimizing washing processes. Material selection plays a crucial role, with brands opting for organic or recycled fibres that require less water during cultivation and processing. Additionally, implementing water recycling systems enables treatment and reuse of water within facilities, minimizing freshwater intake and wastewater discharge, potentially saving finances and the environment. Furthermore, generally investing in innovation for waterless dyeing methods and alternative fabric finishing techniques further enhance brands' efforts to minimize their water footprint. Similarly, any manufacturer can look at their production and change approach and implement alterations.

Attention should also be directed towards packaging. At an operational level, packaging serves to safeguard products throughout transportation and storage until they are sold. Yet, from a marketing perspective, it functions as an extension and enhancer of a brand's identity. Since the wrapping main purpose is covering the product before it is used by a customer it is then immediately thrown away. Excessive wrapping poses a significant problem, generating unnecessary waste, depleting natural resources such as fossil fuels and timber, contributing to habitat destruction and biodiversity loss, having its own economic and production costs. For

these reasons, packaging of products is now starting to be addressed by laws as well. Many bills have already been passed ensuring more conscious approach to product packaging, banning, or penalizing the use of certain non-eco-friendly materials. However, most of the decisions on covering the product lies still on the companies. As society increasingly emphasizes sustainability, packaging emerges as a focal point across various industries. Consumers are seeking reduced packaging, more options for reuse and recycling, and materials sourced from sustainable origins, including compostable and biodegradable alternatives. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

The biggest concern nonetheless is the waste created by manufacturing a product or service provision. How a company manages waste and prevents its generation significantly influences its environmental impact. There are indications that the global waste management system is beginning to embrace principles of circularity. This involves integrating intelligent design into products and improving recycling and reprocessing technologies, which is a crucial step forward. Bans on single-use plastic products as already mentioned have become more widespread, and many local authorities are considering involving informal waste workers in their waste management systems, although not all are doing so. The EU's circular economy strategy emphasizes prioritizing recyclable plastics and reducing single-use plastics. Moreover, numerous corporations, local authorities, and other entities are adopting the circular economy framework to envision a future where waste, energy, and resource use are part of a regenerative model. They are implementing measures to address plastic, electronic, and biological waste. (O'Neill, 2019)

The type and amount of waste generated during the production of individual products vary significantly and are highly individualized. Every company should take responsibility for the waste it produces and, ideally, implement a strategy to ensure proper waste management and recovering of used products. Some companies utilize buy-back programs for used products or offer options for customers to return items to the store or company to guarantee proper disposal of unusable items. The goal for a more sustainable world is to ensure proper handling of relevant waste and to manufacture products that are recyclable or can be reused. (O'Neill, 2019)

1.2.1.2 Place

When targeting Place as one of the pillars of 7 P's the companies need to focus on numerous factors: the supply chain, promotion platforms, retail, and workplace. Starting by their supply chain. The effort to secure suitable suppliers, perform appropriate actions, and ensure timely execution, thus establishing an efficient supply chain, has traditionally served as a competitive advantage. This support to the business is achieved by reducing costs, waste, and time throughout the production and delivery processes. When it comes to sustainability, it is crucial

for organizations to understand their suppliers' credentials, policies, and procedures, given the importance of these interconnections and partnerships. This includes understanding ethical standards, promoting fair labour practices, combatting corruption, and addressing the growing urgency of environmental commitments and progress. Therefore, it is vital for sustainably oriented companies to know their suppliers and supervise their policies and processes. If they are familiar with it, the enterprises can then evaluate through analysis whether it aligns with their goals sufficiently, and if not, change partners or urge existing suppliers to change their behaviours.

Additionally, sustainable practises attach foremost importance to local manufacturers and suppliers. If there is any possibility of shifting towards the local market, it is certainly advisable to do so, even if it is only partially feasible. And there are several reasons for this. Firstly, it is easier to document the sourcing, manufacturing process, and conditions in production, thus making the entire production process more transparent. Secondly, supporting local production and jobs reduces the distances products need to travel, thereby lowering emissions produced. And thirdly, focusing on local suppliers ensures job opportunities, supports the local community, and automatically becomes part of its awareness. It is also the purpose of responsible organizations to educate and motivate others to pursue more ethical alternatives. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

It is simultaneously critical to consider through which channels the firm promotes its products and communicates with customers and even with employees. The offline campaigns were and still are a popular and powerful tool. For example, print, billboards, banners etc. have all costly environmental impact. Manufacturing these materials demands energy, emits greenhouse gases, and produces waste. Moreover, the chemicals and inks utilized in printing may negatively impact the environment if not handled appropriately. Furthermore, the positioning of outdoor advertising installations presents dilemmas. Occasionally, billboards and signage are situated in environmentally delicate zones, disturbing natural scenery, and posing potential threats to indigenous fauna. These issues underscore the importance for the outdoor advertising sector to assess the ecological ramifications of its operations. (360 Hoardings Business, 2023)

There are various practises that make the offline campaigns more environmentally friendly. As mentioned above it is important to assess whether and at what size is the advertising really necessary. Afterwards it is essential to find out how individual aspects impact the environment and where there is room for change. If there is perhaps a possibility to switch to eco-friendly materials such as recyclable or biodegradable substrates, brands can minimize their environmental footprint and contribute to waste reduction. Not to forget the energy consumption and emissions associated with outdoor advertising production processes. Utilizing energy-efficient technologies and practices, as well as sourcing renewable energy sources, can help mitigate the carbon footprint of advertising activities. With offline media it is

also necessary to comprehend the significance of responsible placement of outdoor advertising displays. Brands should avoid installing billboards and signage in ecologically sensitive areas to prevent disruption to natural landscapes and potential harm to local wildlife. And of course, proper waste management in outdoor advertising. Brands should implement recycling and disposal practices that minimize environmental impact and adhere to regulatory requirements. (360 Hoardings Business, 2023)

It might seem “greener” to only do digital or online campaigns and run an e-shop instead of physical store which needs running water, electricity etc. However, the environmental impact associated with websites is on the rise. Every company has a digital footprint, and it is more significant than one may think. On average, each viewed web page generates around 0.5 grams of CO₂ emissions. For a website receiving 10,000 monthly visits, this amounts to approximately fifty kilograms of CO₂ emissions annually. The internet's electricity consumption is significant, coming up to 416.2 terawatt-hours per year, exceeding that of the entire United Kingdom. The carbon footprint and energy demand for loading and delivering web pages continue to escalate across various platforms, including social media, personal websites, and online stores. (Carvill & Butler, 2024) It is upon the marketers to reevaluate what type of content they need to share, whether they need high resolution images, what content on their website and social media truly adds value etc. Ideally, the website should be as easy as possible in order to limit redundant clicks and browsing. Today there is variety of web hosting providers available, it is therefore possible for any firm to choose one that exclusively relies on renewable energy sources to lessen digital environmental impact. (Greenhouse Agency, n.d.) The same applies to television and radio campaigns which additionally add huge environmental cost in the process of producing and filming them. Especially in the case of multinational corporations.

Simultaneously the use of social media is not just about posting content; the cumulative time individuals spend on these platforms is significant and likewise creates digital footprint. While social media remains a valuable communication tool, it is crucial to reassess which platforms align with a company's objectives and prioritize quality over quantity. Monitoring the time both customers and employees invest in social media is essential, ensuring the time is utilized purposefully to discuss environmental and social concerns. (Greenhouse Agency, n.d.)

It is also necessary to consider the organizing of events. Events serve as opportunities for companies for promotion, socialization, networking, or are directly products themselves. Events contribute significantly to carbon emissions, primarily stemming from three main sources: transportation, food, and promotional merchandise. Events, typically falling under the broad umbrella of marketing, encompass a wide spectrum, ranging from small, one-time gatherings to large-scale productions that demand extensive research, planning, organization, logistics, and marketing efforts. Each stage of event planning carries significance in determining the event's impact. As marketers, it is imperative to prioritize sustainability, especially as businesses commit to decarbonization goals, waste reduction initiatives, and efforts to instigate change.

Events present a unique opportunity to demonstrate these commitments in action. Regardless of whether sustainability is the focal point of the event, organizations can leverage the platform, moment, and captive audience to raise awareness and set an example. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

To organize sustainable event, it might be necessary to reflect how all 7 P's of marketing relate to it. There is an immensely helpful guide *The Regenerative Event Checklist* presented in Figure 3. The checklist sums up thirteen ways to make event regenerative and support the UN Sustainable Development Goals. (Global Destination Sustainability Index, n.d.) Nonetheless, it is again up to individual companies how they approach the organization and to consciously consider the SDG.

The Regenerative Event Checklist

13 ways to make your next event regenerative and support the UN Sustainable Development Goals



Consumption	Choice	Communication
1 Reduce, reuse and recycle ...your waste, to encourage a more circular economy. 2 Donate food ...and leftover materials. Which local charities could you support? 3 Go digital ...to remove waste from your event. Could you use electronic signage and an event app? 4 Use the right products ...and event swag. Make sure that they are not single-use, and have as little packaging as possible. 5 Offset your emissions ...with projects that regenerate both nature and communities.	6 Choose a sustainable destination ...that can host regenerative events, and which can be travelled to using sustainable transport. 7 Choose a venue that sources clean energy ...can recycle waste, and has easy public transport access. 8 Choose local, sustainable suppliers ...and materials. Check if they are sustainability certified. 9 Choose sustainable food What can be served in bulk? Can your caterer prepare delicious vegetarian meals?	10 Empower attendees ...to bring their own water bottle and conference bag. Also, collect accurate numbers of attendees to reduce avoidable food waste. 11 Measure your impact ...on the environment and society, and report this to delegates, your stakeholders, and the public. 12 Educate exhibitors ...on how they can contribute to creating a more regenerative event. Can you award best practices? 13 Be transparent Share your sustainability policy, procurement policy, and relevant sustainability certifications with clients and on your website.
	www.gds-index.com	

Figure 3: The regenerative Event Checklist, from: <https://www.gds.earth/wp-content/uploads/The-Regenerative-Event-Checklist-GDS-Index.pdf>

Part of committing company to sustainability is also a transformation of the workplace. That concerns physical stores, offices, factories, laboratories, centres etc. The spaces where the company operates or exerts influence present significant environmental challenges thus must be properly addressed. Primarily, they should aim to eliminate disposable products and replace them with reusable alternatives. Setting up recycling bins and using packaging only when necessary, or opting for reusable formats, can significantly reduce waste. Switching to

renewable electricity sources and implementing energy-efficient practices, such as using LED lighting and optimizing heating and cooling systems, can help minimize energy consumption and carbon emissions. Encouraging employees to reduce their carbon footprint by promoting alternatives to driving, such as carpooling or using public transportation, is also beneficial. Additionally, sourcing office supplies from sustainable and eco-friendly vendors and implementing telecommuting or flexible work schedules to reduce the need for commuting and office space are effective strategies. Setting measurable goals for waste reduction, energy consumption, and carbon emissions, and tracking progress regularly, can ensure accountability and continuous improvement in sustainability efforts.

Generally transforming the workplace of a company is a great way how to demonstrate honest interest in sustainable practises and lead the way for others.

1.2.1.3 Price

Free markets can have detrimental effects on both the environment and society because they often fail to accurately account for the full costs associated with the production and consumption of goods and services. Due to their reliance on pricing mechanisms, markets tend to prioritize vendors offering the lowest prices, which may, and usually does conceal the highest unacknowledged expenses. (Hawken, 2013)

In usual practice, marketers often prioritize several factors like competitive pricing, value addition, loss-leading strategies, promotional pricing, early bird offers, and discounts. However, when examining pricing from a broader perspective of sustainable marketing, marketers should delve into ethical pricing, the impact on the supply chain, regulatory compliance, unsustainable consumption, and transparency. This involves asking critical questions: Does this pricing strategy exert excessive pressure on the supply chain? Is the price inadvertently encouraging unethical practices within the chain? Does the price reflect and allow for fair wages? Is there enough transparency regarding pricing? Is the price inadvertently promoting irresponsible consumption habits? (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

In sustainable business, price should correspond to fair trade, ethical partnerships, supply chain integrity, and fair wages. From a marketing standpoint, the focus should be on setting reasonable price points and most importantly providing incentives, emphasizing the advantages of sustainable options, and ensuring accessibility. Instead of attaching premium prices to sustainable choices, efforts should be directed towards offering clear information and explanations about why the product benefits the planet and people. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

There are many issues with right and fair pricing on the market in general. Of course, it primarily concerns companies that do not incorporate fair pricing at all, push prices down, and thus promote consumerism. Secondly, it also involves companies that claim that the price reflects

sustainable development but do not substantiate their claim in any way - this is therefore considered greenwashing. And lastly many organizations are incorporating sustainability into their operations, but often, this involves imposing exaggerated premiums on products. The added price for a climate-friendly product is up to between 75 and 85 percent. This creates a dilemma. While the desire for profit motivates such practices, it might also show a deliberate attempt to portray sustainability as expensive and inconvenient. By dampening demand, organizations avoid making significant and costly changes to their operations, opting instead to make superficial adjustments. Unfortunately, this strategy has a flaw: it complicates and increases the cost of inevitable changes for said companies in the long term. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

The pricing is an overly complex theme across sustainable market. It is a crucial starting point if a company is to operate based on sustainable principles. However, it is closely linked to positioning. As the company often needs to increase prices to reflect the true costs of manufacturing, processes, fair wages, etc., it ends up attracting customers with similar beliefs who prioritize the greater good over attractive prices and discounts.

1.2.1.4 Promotion

Arguably what is marketing most connected to is promotion. Advertising, exclusive offers, partnerships, campaigns are all part of it. The common goal for marketers was to persuade customers to buy their product, preferably to keep buying it and to purchase it even if it is not necessary. Clearly it is one of the main factors which leads to overconsumption, excessive spending, and unnecessary waste.

The main idea of sustainable promotion is not to focus on growth which might seem to contradict the usual marketing narrative. The objectives should be deconsumption or more sensible consumption. In today's business environment, the reputation of a brand is intricately intertwined with its sustainability efforts. The task for marketers is to ensure that sustainability is communicated effectively, both within the organization and to the public. Being well-informed about the evolving business landscape, particularly in terms of sustainability and brand reputation, is crucial. It is essential to possess the necessary knowledge to substantiate and reinforce the messages we convey. In other words, change attitude towards promotion. Promote the sustainable ideas and most importantly educate customers and employees about the companies' philosophy and motivate them to also change their behaviour. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

The base of a truly sustainable marketing mindset should be transparency. Even admitting the company is not 100% sustainable nor using only renewable resources is in the long term beneficial for the brand. Honesty is what is valued. Customers appreciate the transparency and

seeing the company truly makes effort to towards better environmental performance is a trust establishing factor. The trust is achieved by showcasing the ongoing advancements and effects the firms are accomplishing or addressing. Such dedication to maintaining a certain level of transparency plays a crucial role in advancing the sustainability agenda, fostering transformation, and, notably, yielding tangible outcomes. Moreover, transparency extends beyond corporate sustainability initiatives, encompassing details regarding product life cycles—from extraction and distribution to eventual disposal—along with associated plans, timelines, and progress updates. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

However, the sustainable claims are very difficult to trace. This allows many companies to leverage the positive impact of marketing so-called sustainable products, while the reality is completely different. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

As of March 2023, the European Commission has put forth a new legislation proposing updated criteria to prevent companies from making deceptive assertions regarding the environmental benefits of their offerings. The proposal comes in response to findings indicating that 53 percent of green assertions provide vague, misleading, or unfounded information, while 40 percent lack supporting evidence. Additionally, it was found that half of all green labels lack robust verification processes or are altogether weak. (European Commission, n.d.) With an issue so broad it is important for sustainable marketing teams to radically distinct the business from such practises and to alert if they occur. The right attitude is again based on transparency and trust between the company and the customer.

In addition to transparent, educational, and clear communication in promotion, partnerships play a crucial role. We can consider suppliers, collaborating companies, organizations, etc., as partnerships. This applies not only to ecological and socially responsible endeavours but also to partnerships established specifically for sustainable goals. Conscious businesses often support organizations dedicated to giving back to nature or communities. For instance, they may invest in tree-planting initiatives aimed at offsetting the company's carbon footprint. Other examples include collaborating with renewable energy providers, supporting sustainable agriculture initiatives, investing in fair-trade, and engaging in waste reduction programs. By investing or collaborating with these types of organization the companies truly show the purpose matter just as much as income. And that is what a responsible customer wants to see. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

1.2.1.5 People

The People in marketing mix represent how everyone who is included in the process is treated. The most pressing issues in business include discrimination, inequality, lack of communication with employees, unfair trade, and poor wages.

Ensuring workplace equality is impossible in the presence of discrimination. Discrimination can manifest in several ways, such as bias related to gender, sexual orientation, race, age, physical or mental abilities, pregnancy, and religious beliefs. When a business pays different salaries to employees holding the same position based on any of these characteristics, it engages in discriminatory practices. Similarly, discrimination occurs when certain individuals are denied compensation or benefits, or when they are excluded from recruitment and promotional opportunities due to these traits. Not always is the company itself or its leadership directly involved in such behaviour. However, a company that aims to act socially responsibly must respond to these issues and apply systemic thinking and solutions. It needs to denounce such practices and implement preventive measures to prevent them from occurring. (Carvill & Butler, 2024) (Human Rights Careers, n.d.)

Businesses must start by committing to change and closely examining their current practices. They need to ensure that all employment equality laws are being upheld and address any evident issues such as poor living wages, child labour etc. Other common challenge is the pay gap between genders. The companies should analyse their financial records to achieve greater equality. Transparency about salary for every position is one of the vastly used socially responsible tactics. When hiring and promoting employees with an equality mindset, senior management should examine job qualifications. They need to assess whether any qualifications requirements might prevent certain groups from applying and whether traditional criteria, such as educational background or office experience, are disproportionately considered. Asking these questions can uncover potential discrimination practices within the company. (Human Rights Careers, n.d.)

Encouraging a safe work environment is another crucial step toward achieving equality. And to disclaim or alter any practices that are not in line with SDGs. Employees should feel comfortable approaching the executives with any issues, ideas, or request. Equality in the workplace goes beyond avoiding discrimination based on traits like gender, sexuality, and race. It requires a commitment to self-reflection and improvement. While no workplace is perfect, the leading ones support diverse environment where learning and development are valued. Above all, employees should feel valued and respected. (Human Rights Careers, n.d.)

It is not only necessary to address these issues within the company but also analyse the operations of the companies' partners and suppliers. Fostering the fair-trade process is unequivocally the right path. It is then up to the company whether to encourage its suppliers to adopt different behaviour or to terminate cooperation with them and start supporting already functioning socially responsible businesses.

Of course, the mentioned issues are not directly under the marketing department. However, when a company decides to operate as a socially responsible business, it must consider all aspects. It is the responsibility of marketers to advocate for more sustainable practices across

all departments of the company and then transparently inform employees and customers to gain their trust and demonstrate the company's intentions.

1.2.1.6 Process

The process represents the whole trajectory of businesses' operations. From the supply chain and product creation to the procurement of electricity, fuels, and water, through transportation and distribution, to the use of the product, communication with customers, and the overall functioning of the company. In the process is where most waste and emissions are created. Organizations need to start to question their complete process and make changes where possible to offset their emissions and reduce waste. (GHS, n.d.)

Sustainable marketers must initially gain a thorough comprehension of waste generation and prevention mechanisms to guide their product and distribution strategies towards minimizing ecological impact. The goal is to introduce environmentally friendly products into the market that meet both customer satisfaction and business targets. (Fuller, 1999) For this objective the companies rethink their relationship to waste. Implementing different strategies for waste management that focus on reducing, reusing, recycling, refurbishing, or repurposing the discard is necessary for the purpose of slowing down the excessive impact on the finite resources and pollution. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

It is necessary to focus on the supply chain again. It is essential for marketers to educate themselves about the working methods of suppliers and all partners involved in the making of a product. Where they source materials from, how they process them, what the manufacturing process entails, and so forth. Nowadays, people are becoming more mindful of their consumption habits, they demand the information, they want to know the entire life cycle of the product, from supplier processes to manufacturing and transportation. Therefore, ensuring transparency throughout the supply chain helps build credibility and appeal to conscientious consumers. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

Communication with customers is equally important and is part of the Process. It does not necessarily address sustainability directly, but it is closely connected to transparency. Addressing complaints, replying to customers, and most importantly listening to what customers are looking for, demand to change, or appreciate about the business is a leading step forward.

When reviewing transportation and distribution, two central factors to consider are the mode of transportation and the distance covered. These factors are relevant not only to the product but also to the workforce. Various organizations that offer carbon offsetting, for example through reforestation efforts, exist. Nonetheless, carbon offsets alone cannot effectively address climate change unless major carbon emitters commit to achieving carbon neutrality.

This entails establishing sustainable supply chains and dedicated efforts to transition to renewable and clean energy sources. (Lutkewitch, n.d.) In the case of transporting products and materials, there are only limited solutions because transportation itself will always generate emissions and consume energy. Therefore, it is advantageous to collaborate with local businesses. This not only reduces the distance products need to travel but also supports the local economy and enables better control and information regarding production. Furthermore, reducing the frequency of product transportation and consolidating shipments into larger quantities generally leads to lower environmental emissions per unit of delivered product. Similarly, it is advisable to review storage facilities. Ensuring that the amount of inventory matches the demand for sales more accurately results in reduced inventory levels, requiring less storage space and allowing for more efficient utilization of smaller storage facilities. This ultimately leads to cost savings. (Fuller, 1999)

In the topic of transportation, employees should also be considered. If they must commute to work, it is advisable to motivate them to use public transportation or cycle. In cases where physical presence at the office or company headquarters is not necessary, it is suitable to introduce alternatives such as working from home. Remote work is a very modern practice, and thanks to it, office space can be significantly reduced, thus cutting down on energy consumption, saving time, and, most importantly, minimizing unnecessary commuting.

For a marketer is fundamental to understand the process of a company – the plans, targets, and commitments, and be able to communicate it well. And especially in the context of process to consider any implications of greenwashing. (Carvill & Butler, 2024)

1.2.1.7 Physical evidence

The marketers and brand managers are well aware of the demand for more eco-conscious products. Therefore, misleading environmental claims have become common. Unfortunately, there are not many regulations or laws ensuring the truthfulness of these claims and falsifications are rarely punished. Hence it is up to the responsibility of the business to transparently communicate their efforts and substantiating it, for example, with certificates, proofs, or regular reports.

Customers typically assess the quality of the service based on physical evidence. The same applies to sustainability assessment. The setting in which the service is delivered, along with any physical items that support the service's performance and communication, is crucial. Similarly, the visible surroundings can shape customers' perceptions of service quality. In terms of retail store, the physical environment includes factors such as ambiance, the layout of the service area, seating comfort, background music, and the appearance of staff members. These aspects significantly impact a customer's satisfaction with their service experience. It is

appropriate to focus environmental conscious changes on both the store and delivery. (Abdul-Hamid, Inkumsah, & Angenu, 2022)

Likewise, the approach to the functioning of offices, storage spaces, and factories influences feelings about the company's environmental activities. In this case, it mainly involves changes that concern employees, who of course must also be addressed when aiming for reduced emissions, pollution, and waste of the firm.

1.2.2 The role of sustainable marketing in business strategy

Sustainability is no longer "nice to have". It is a differentiator and a driver of purchasing decisions. According to recent study by Simon-Kucher (2021), 50% of consumers rank sustainability as a top five value driver on average across categories, which means it is an important purchase criterion and is a key differentiator in the overall value proposition. Moreover, 78% of consumers aspire to live more sustainable lives and plan to do more environmentally friendly choices in the future. This trend is particularly relevant for younger generations who are actively looking for more conscious way of living. (Simon-Kucher, 2021) As shown in Figure 4 the revenue share of sustainable apparel worldwide is rapidly growing. This sends a clear signal that the market potential for sustainable businesses is enormous, and it will continue to grow even further in the future.

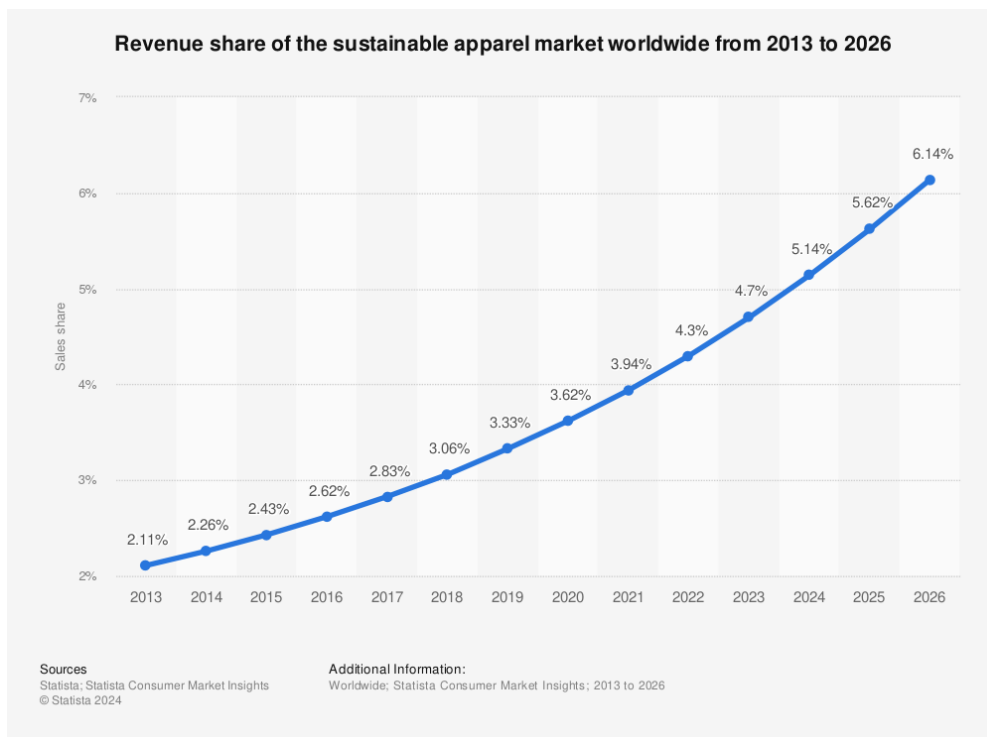


Figure 4: Statista. (April 21, 2023). Revenue share of the sustainable apparel market worldwide from 2013 to 2026 [Graph]. In Statista. Retrieved April 16, 2024, from <https://www-statista-com.zdroje.vse.cz/forecasts/1307848/worldwide-sales-of-sustainable-clothing-items>

The ecological and ethical aspects of products are progressively emerging as a crucial factor across various categories, making it a significant criterion for purchase and a key distinguishing element in the overall value proposition. Between the years 2015 and 2021 sustainability-marketed products grew 2.7x faster than conventionally marketed products, and 2.1x faster than the CPG market. It is evident that the demand for sustainable products has been consistently increasing over the long term. Environmentally friendly products might eventually completely transfer from the pleasant benefit to essential requirement for the customers. They are changing the market already in a significant way. (NYU, 2022)

The costumers are now wiser than ever to the presence of greenwashing and many demand ecologically made and promoted products. Companies are being challenged to show the origin and production of their item. And the ones who had done the change to responsibility and transparency are showing remarkable results. When asked only 1.75% of business owners answered the results after investing in sustainable marketing strategies had negative impact on their brand image. That implies that more than 90% of companies see a benefit in it. Several of the leading results of investing into sustainable marketing strategies are in fact positive brand image, loyal customers, and increased sales. The key effects are outlined in the statistics presented in Figure 5.

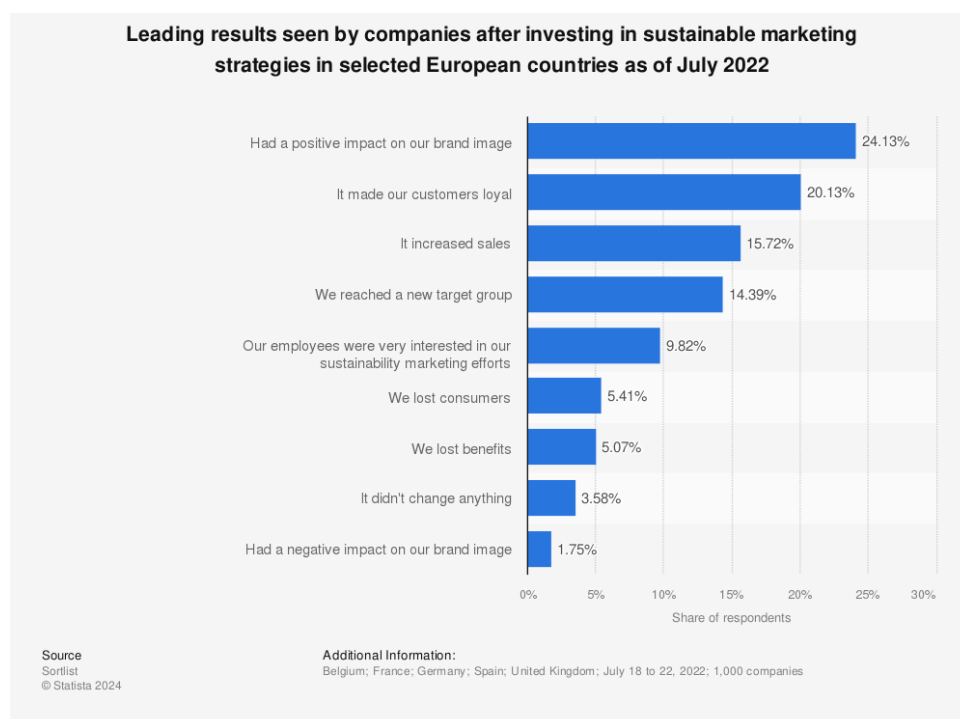


Figure 5:Sortlist. (September 9, 2022). Leading results seen by companies after investing in sustainable marketing strategies in selected European countries as of July 2022 [Graph]. In Statista. Retrieved April 16, 2024, from <https://www-statista-com.zdroje.vse.cz/statistics/1338564/top-results-from-sustainable-marketing-in-europe/>

The call for responsible actions is not only on the side of customers. It affects the job market as well. Young employees increasingly demand careers that are purpose driven. There are multiple researches showing the company's active behaviour toward sustainable production is one of key consideration for job applicants looking for meaningful and impactful career. (The Stepsone group, 2023)

It is only logical to presume that businesses will drive the most change if sustainable decisions also provide financial incentive. Some governments are preparing sanctions for businesses that do not use more environmentally friendly or recycled materials or do not implement any sustainable initiatives. That way sustainable thinking would bring more economic benefit and motivate more firms to participate. The Czech Republic responded with a law passed in 2022 that bans the production of some selected single-use plastic products. These include plastic cotton buds, plastic cutlery, plates, straws, stirrers, balloon sticks, food containers, cups and beverage containers made of expanded polystyrene and products made of oxo-degradable plastics. Moreover, the law will also help to further reduce waste, as it imposes an obligation on companies to inform buyers about the correct disposal of waste and to label plastic products. The law also strengthens the so-called extended producer responsibility for selected plastic waste. Some companies will thus have to participate in the cleaning up of waste from their products in municipalities. Municipalities will thus receive financial contributions for cleaning. These are the first steps towards motivating responsible behaviour on the part of producers. (Ministerstvo životního prostředí, 2022)

Most large companies showcase their commitments and activities through ESG performance. ESG stands for Environmental, Social and Governance. A framework evaluating company's environmental and social impact. The ESG rating are becoming key indicator of values and performance. What is more, The European Council and Parliament agreed on regulating ESG ratings to boost investor confidence in sustainable investments. The new rules aim to improve transparency and prevent conflicts of interest by requiring ESG rating providers to be authorized and supervised. This will make ESG ratings more reliable and comparable, ultimately encouraging companies to adopt more sustainable practices. (Council of the EU, 2024) The obligation applies to a broad range of companies. This includes all large, medium-sized, and small companies listed on the stock exchange. Additionally, any company meeting at least two of the following three criteria will also be subject to this requirement: Annual turnover of at least one billion Czech crowns, more than 250 employees, assets on the balance sheet exceeding 500 million Czech crowns. (Frank Bold Advisory, 2023)

The legislatures also respond by punishing greenwashing and falsification of sustainable products, specifically unsubstantiated sustainability claims on labels, failing to follow ESG investment policies or sharing generally misleading information about manufacturing process or product. Biggest corporate greenwashing fines worldwide as of 2023 are shown in Figure 6.

Company	Fine in million U.S. dollars	Accusation
Volkswagen	34,690	Implementing software that falsified data and helped evade emissions tests on its vehicles.
Toyota	180	Delayed sharing of emissions-related reports.
DWS	25	Marketing ESG funds as “greener” than they actually were.
Eni	5.6	Claiming its palm oil diesel was “green”.
Kohl's & Walmart*	5.5	Claiming their products were made from environmentally friendly bamboo when they were made from other materials.
Goldman Sachs	4	Failing to follow ESG investment policies and misleading its customers.
Keurig	2.2	Making misleading claims about its single-use coffee pods.
BNY Mellon	1.5	Failing to implement ESG policies and overstating the ESG value of its funds.
H&M	0.43	Making unsubstantiated sustainability claims on their labels.
Decathlon	0.53	Making unsubstantiated sustainability claims on their labels.

Showing entries 1 to 10 (10 entries in total)

Details: Worldwide; As of 2023; Figures are converted to U.S. dollars.

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Figure 6: Cleanhub. (February 7, 2024). Biggest corporate greenwashing fines worldwide as of 2023, by company (in million U.S. dollars) [Graph]. In Statista. Retrieved April 16, 2024, from <https://www-statista-com.zdroje.vse.cz/statistics/1459160/biggest-greenwashing-fines-worldwide-by-company/>

2 PRACTICAL PART

The practical analyses the Freshlabels brand as an example of how a brand operates in the Czech market, emphasizing the right ecological and social approach to business. Initially, it will describe the brand based on its presentation on its website and social media, followed by an analysis based on an interview with CEO Ladislav Žižka. The second part will interpret interviews with customers and potential customers of the brand, examining their perceptions and attitudes towards both the brand and sustainable marketing. This will provide information for the comparison of the public's understanding of sustainable marketing and their associated perceptions. Additionally, this analysis explores how a brand can present itself when transitioning to become a store solely dedicated to sustainable brands.

2.1 BRAND ANALYSIS

2.1.1 Freshlabels analysis

The following chapter presents findings from research of Freshlabels, a retail store renowned for its commitment to sustainability in its operations and brand selection. The information provided is from their website, social media accounts, physical stores, and interview with the CEO. This brand is considered a pioneer in sustainable fashion in the Czech Republic. The goal of this analysis is to determine the extent to which this brand is committed to sustainable marketing and how it reflects conscious behaviour in all aspects of its operations.

2.1.1.1 Company overview

Freshlabels.cz is a Czech online retailer specializing in men's and women's apparel, footwear, backpacks, and accessories. Founded on the concept of conscious consumerism, Freshlabels focuses on curating high-quality, well-designed products that prioritize sustainability and ethical production practices.

Freshlabels offers a range of products that cater to a style-conscious audience seeking clothing, shoes, and accessories that go beyond just aesthetics. The focus is on timeless design and durability, with an emphasis on brands that prioritize environmental and social responsibility. Some of the featured brands include Fjällräven, Veja, Dr. Martens, and Ucon Acrobatics, known for their commitment to sustainable materials and ethical manufacturing.

Freshlabels differentiates itself by actively promoting eco-friendly practices. The website highlights products made from recycled materials and features a dedicated category for

sustainable items. This focus caters to a growing segment of consumers who are increasingly conscious of the environmental impact of fashion choices.

Freshlabels' mission statement, "Go beyond the surface," reflects their commitment to offering products that represent more than just fashion. They target individuals who value quality, design, and a mindful approach to consumption. The focus on ethically sourced and sustainable products positions Freshlabels to resonate with environmentally conscious consumers.

Overall, Freshlabels.cz stands out as a Czech online retailer offering a curated selection of fashion items that cater to the growing demand for sustainable and ethically produced clothing, footwear, and accessories.

2.1.1.2 CEO interview

I managed to contact Freshlabels CEO Ladislav Žižka, who gave me an interview and then arranged for me to attend a company event, which gave me the opportunity to see their marketing strategy in practise. The meeting took place online on March 13th, and subsequently, I inquired about more details via email. The Freshlabels event was on April 11th. It was the launch of a new brand into the Freshlabels portfolio, specifically the Winqs brand, which offers sports sneakers and apparel made entirely from sustainable materials.

The interview delved into various aspects of the company's sustainable practices, its philosophy, marketing strategies, collaborations with brands, compliance with standards, feedback mechanisms, and key performance indicators. The interview scenario is provided in Appendix A.

The interview with the CEO of Freshlabels provides valuable insights into the company's sustainable practices and its integration into various aspects of its operations. The findings underscore the importance of quality products in retail and the multifaceted approach required to enact meaningful change within the industry.

2.1.1.2.1 Presentation of findings

According to the CEO, Freshlabels' commitment to sustainability stems from a deep-seated conviction there is a way to run successful business and minimize environmental impact simultaneously. While acknowledging the necessity for profitability, the company integrates sustainable practices into its business model without compromising financial viability.

Freshlabels recognizes the challenges of making sustainability the standard in the fashion industry. The prices of sustainable materials and production mechanisms remain very high and

complex, making them inaccessible to many, resulting in products manufactured this way being more expensive. Because they are more expensive, they do not reach the entire society, and thus their production cannot become cheaper. It is a complete cycle from which there is currently no way out. Conscious production primarily depends on a company's setup. This was mainly discussed at the Wings & Freshlabels event. For a company that has been producing goods for a long time, it is harder to completely change its supply chain and transition to more environmentally and socially friendly practices. Of course, it is possible, but companies try many ways to circumvent it to avoid losses. Often, they will produce one product in their entire portfolio using a more sustainable material and promote it to attract customers.

Freshlabels primarily operates as a reseller, curating brands that prioritize quality, design, and sustainability. Its sustainability strategy focuses on four main pillars: quality products, unique production methods, extensive research for brand selection, and ongoing improvement through customer feedback and service enhancement. They value and appreciate sustainably made products, however, they find quality, functionality, and usefulness of the product more environmentally friendly in the long run. The goal is to create a product that customers can use for a long time, does not go out of style, and is practical. It does not generate unnecessary waste and is not discarded after just a few uses. Building on this idea of longevity, Freshlabels has launched a new initiative called Freshlabels Loop, where customers can bring back clothing purchased in the store that they no longer use. Freshlabels ensures the proper processing of materials, and in exchange, offers a discount on their next purchase.

The company's marketing efforts align with its sustainability claims, emphasizing community building, educational initiatives, and event-based promotions. They use social media, influencers, and physical stores as marketing channels, highlighting sustainability as a key brand attribute. Their main effort is to establish relationships with communities, such as runners, hikers, cyclists, etc. They also engage with students, organizing educational lectures to educate them on sustainability issues and brand business practices. They host events that connect with the brand and build brand awareness within the community.

Freshlabels collaborates with brands that align with its sustainability principles. While smaller brands often approach the company, Freshlabels also actively seeks partnerships through research and participation in trade fairs across Europe. As a retailer, Freshlabels prioritizes ensuring its suppliers have relevant sustainability certifications. While primarily focusing on product manufacturers' certifications, the company also engages in ongoing efforts to enhance its sustainability initiatives. They strive to find ways to operate their branches correctly, organize events, etc. However, the origin of products and their production are managed by the brands they discover.

The company measures sustainability by the proportion of sustainable brands in its portfolio, aiming for a balance between sustainability, quality, and design. Campaign success is evaluated

using traditional metrics such as brand awareness, online search increase, and return on investment. They gather feedback from customers through various channels, including personal interviews, social media, and customer hotlines. Feedback plays a crucial role in shaping the company's initiatives and future actions.

2.1.1.3 Marketing mix

The individual chapters Product, Price, Place, Promotion, People, Process, Physical evidence analyse Freshlabels actions towards more sustainable functioning of the business. Their approach is evaluated according to 7 P's through Responsible Sustainable Marketing Lens which is a theory discussed in the Definition and principles of sustainable marketing chapter of the theoretical part of this thesis. See Figure 7 for graphic information about individual actions taken by Freshlabels toward more responsible business behaviour.

Product

The company is a resell store, hence the products they sell are not made directly by Freshlabels. However, their commitment to sustainability and social responsibility extends to their product selection and customer service. They carefully curate a collection of high-quality, stylish brands that align with their ecological and ethical values.

Beyond offering exceptional products with timeless designs and premium artisanry, Freshlabels goes the extra mile by providing the service of comprehensive and easily available information about the brands and products they feature. This commitment to transparency empowers customers to make informed decisions and gain a deeper understanding of the origins and production methods behind each item. The process begins with filling out a questionnaire, where Freshlabels asks about materials, dyeing, social responsibility, supply chain knowledge, transportation distance, support for other organizations with higher goals and certifications. Whether and to what extent they burden the environment, whether through chemical fertilization and excessive water consumption or the production of new synthetic fibres. Whether the colouring is natural or does not burden either the environment or the workers who handle the dyes. Whether more than two-thirds of their products are manufactured in factories where regular audits ensure safe working conditions, respect for human rights and adequate wages. To what level and to what depth they know their supply chain. What is the distance of the entire production chain from the transport of raw materials to the delivery of the final product to the warehouse. Whereby for a positive evaluation, it should not exceed 10,000 km or whether they compensate for their carbon footprint with other activities. The answers are then scored, and the brands are then given a rating on a scale of 0-7. Whereby 0 is for brands that did not fill out the questionnaire, 3 for brands that are dedicated to the

sustainable agenda but do not have everything perfect, 5 for brands that are doing a great job and are environmentally conscious, and 7 for brands that are leaders, are comprehensively and consistently committed to sustainability and should rightfully be a model for others. The proportion of products from truly sustainable brands at Freshlabels is 66%. Currently, they have thirty-three active brands in their portfolio that are labelled as Sustainable Tag, so they meet more than half of the evaluation criteria.

At the same time, they also focus on packaging and offer customers the option of having their orders shipped in reused packaging. They obtain boxes from both customers themselves and partners from among companies. Currently, they send more than 50% of all shipments without the need to use newly manufactured packaging. But we also manufacture new packaging from as many recycled materials as possible and, if necessary, use old, shredded cardboard as filling instead of bubble wrap. And directly in the store, instead of giving away disposable bags for free, they offer a shopper bag made of organic cotton with GOTS certification or a sturdy recycled paper bag.

Price

It is hard to judge whether the price of products is fair or not. However, with their survey they also take in account fair wages, fair trade, and social responsibility. Therefore, we can assume the prices of pieces tagged with sustainable tag should be appropriate. In the interview with Ladislav Žižka we also discussed the prices of sustainable products. They are generally more expensive. Sometimes not only because of more expensive manufacturing and materials but also because many position themselves as a luxury product which often go hand in hand, this is not always the case. Some brands exploit the sustainability trend by positioning their products as premium and increasing their margins. As a result, sustainable products are often inaccessible, and since they do not sell in large volumes, mass production and cost reduction are not feasible.

As much as they approach the pricing responsibly, they engage in promotional campaigns like back-to-school sales, spring sales, and the like, which are typical tactics that promote consumerism and irresponsible spending. In addition to incentivizing more people to buy products, these sales also indicate that the set prices are flexible, which is not ideal when sustainability is a priority. However, as mentioned in the interview, the main priority for any business is to make money, and therefore, evidently, not all their marketing practices are entirely environmentally friendly, and they implement price gimmicks.

Place

In terms of geographic footprint, we consider where a product is manufactured, promoted, and sold. For Freshlabels, manufacturing is outsourced to the brands they represent. While they commendably conduct sustainability surveys to ensure these brands adhere to environmentally and socially responsible practices, aiming for 100% sustainable representation is a significant step forward. However, Freshlabels currently lacks local production or Czech-made products in its portfolio. This presents two key challenges. Firstly, the need to transport products globally increases their carbon footprint. While Freshlabels may delegate responsibility to their brands, their business model necessitates this transportation, making them indirectly accountable. Secondly, overseeing production, supply chains, and working conditions becomes more difficult at a distance, relying solely on brand statements and survey responses. Supporting local production, however, is a cornerstone of sustainable consumption and there is a massive potential.

Freshlabels prioritizes environmental impact in their promotional strategies, limiting the use of posters, flyers, giveaways, and similar materials. This approach is commendable, but they do not currently plan to eliminate these marketing formats entirely.

Their primary channel is their website, which combines an e-commerce store, a blog, and a section explaining their stance on sustainability. While they have not yet considered their digital footprint, the e-shop is relatively clear and user-friendly. Unlike other brands with overwhelming product catalogues, Freshlabels offers a manageable selection, preventing customers from spending hours searching for specific items. This aligns with their goal of minimizing digital footprint. The website also features a blog called "Discovermag," which provides information on the latest trends, products, collaborations, and other related topics. Its primary purpose is to encourage purchases. Similarly, their social media presence includes daily product updates and a regular newsletter for subscribers. While they strive to share educational content about materials, initiatives, and sustainable practices, the overall focus remains on driving consumption.

Freshlabels demonstrates a commitment to sustainability in their product selection and manufacturing processes. However, their promotional strategies could be further refined to align with their environmental goals. By reducing reliance on physical marketing materials and focusing on informative and engaging digital content, they can minimize their digital footprint and promote sustainable consumption more effectively.

Freshlabels operates two physical stores in Prague: the Sustainable Store Letná and the Flagship Store Jindřišská, which was designed in collaboration with studio deFORM. The interior of the Letná store, which also houses their offices, is the result of a partnership with Lenka Míková Architects and features recycled and upcycled materials, prioritizing durability. Environmental

considerations extend to store operations. While information on energy sources is lacking, a commitment to responsible practices is evident. They have signed the Dopper PET FREE pledge, eliminating single-use PET water bottles from their workplaces. All offices, warehouses, and stores diligently recycle waste, a practice that should be standard. Additionally, their stores serve as event venues, minimizing environmental impact by avoiding employee travel, commute, renting and venue setup, which often generate waste. They also approach catering and event content responsibly. At their recent event with Wings, they sourced food from a local vegan butcher shop and beverages from small local businesses. Only limited number of people is usually invited to the event which also saves energy consumption. They use recycled paper tableware and project information on screens, significantly reducing event-related waste.

Promotion

While Freshlabels promotes sustainable and high-quality products, their marketing tactics, driven by profit maximization, often encourage overconsumption and manipulate customers into purchasing more. As acknowledged in an interview, profit remains their primary focus. While they successfully project a green brand image, their practices do not always align with environmental principles. For instance, limited-time sales pressure quick purchases, seasonal new collection drops, and promotional discounts mirror fast fashion brand strategies.

Transparency, a cornerstone of any company striving for improvement, is highly valued by Freshlabels. They acknowledge their imperfections and the non-completeness of their sustainable portfolio, a commendable approach compared to brands that label products as 'green' without substantiation. They strive for transparency in product evaluations and sourcing, continuously reviewing this data. However, verifying the veracity of these claims remains challenging.

Their primary marketing channel is social media, where they collaborate with influencers, brands, and organizations to reach their target audience. This effective strategy expands their brand awareness. Brand collaborations are complemented by event organization, often coinciding with new brand partnerships or collection launches. They also actively engage with the community by supporting various cultural events, including the Metronome Festival, Mezipatra, and Signal Festival. They also extend their support to sporting events and environmental initiatives like Clean Up Day. These events generate content and provide customers with added value. These practises remain consumption oriented. Nonetheless, as part of their campaigns, Freshlabels endeavours to educate consumers about manufacturing processes and the issues surrounding fast fashion. This approach aligns with the principles of sustainable marketing, promoting informed consumer choices and encouraging a move away from environmentally harmful practices.

People

Freshlabels' primary source of information regarding labour conditions in their manufacturing processes is the Sustainable Tag questionnaire, which includes a few relevant questions. While fair wages and worker well-being are considered important principles, direct assessment of wages is not possible. However, the company fosters a positive work environment focused on sustainability, which employees appreciate. Beyond the workplace, Freshlabels addresses human rights issues through non-intrusive campaigns. Their advertisements feature diverse models of various sizes, skin tones, ages, and sexual orientations. They also support the queer festival Mezipatra and discuss equality issues on their blog. Overall, they demonstrate a commitment to equality, but it is not heavily emphasized, perhaps perceived as an inherent value.

Process

Freshlabels' process begins by discovering, identifying, and reaching out to brands they deem interesting and of high-quality. Each brand receives a questionnaire assessing their sustainability practices, environmental impact, material usage, and other relevant factors. This transparency-driven approach is a core value for Freshlabels.

While they support fewer local brands, resulting in more transportation, most shipments are sent in reusable packaging. They also prioritize paperless returns and exchanges to minimize waste.

Freshlabels demonstrates a commitment to the lifecycle of its products through their Freshlabels Loop program. This initiative allows customers to return previously purchased items that they no longer need. Products meeting specific criteria can be returned in-store or via Zásilkovna. In return, customers receive store credit and the assurance that their pre-loved items will not end up in landfills. Usable items are offered for sale at Loop Market events, while others are upcycled, recycled, or donated to charities. This approach cleverly combines waste reduction with customer loyalty building.

Physical evidence

The judging of evidence primarily relies on certifications to demonstrate their commitment to sustainability. However, since they are a resale company and most certifications refer to product manufacturing, which ultimately falls under the responsibility of the original producers, there is only limited certification available. Therefore, the company's questionnaire also includes a question about certifications and provides information about certification which each product.

Freshlabels themselves hold the "Heureka Sustainable E-shop" certificate, a project initiated by Heureka.cz, Visa, Komerční banka, and the Association for Social Responsibility. The involvement of the latter organization ensures a responsible and objective evaluation of participating e-shops.

Additional evidence of Freshlabels' sustainability practices lies in the products themselves, with transparent information about their origin provided on the website and in physical stores. Notably, the Letná store is partially constructed from recycled materials.

Revisiting Freshlabels' 7 P's through a Responsible Marketing Lens

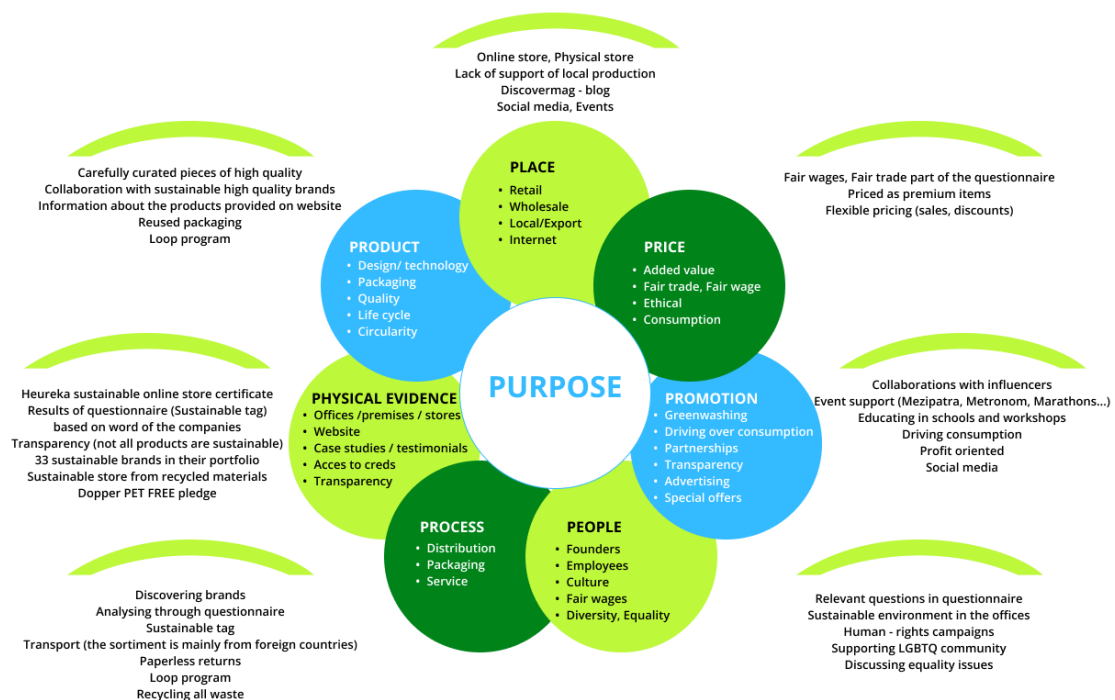


Figure 7: Revisiting Freshlabels' 7 P's through a Responsible Marketing Lens (source: Author)

2.1.1.4 Analysis and discussion

Freshlabels demonstrates a strong commitment to responsible business practices, actively seeking sustainable solutions across all aspects of their operations. Their Loop Club project, which allows customers to return unused clothing for proper handling and waste reduction, stands out as a notable initiative. The company's core strength lies in their Sameboot tool and the comprehensive questionnaire they send to brands, which I have mentioned repeatedly. This combination provides a unique and valuable service to customers, enabling informed decisions about product sustainability.

However, a question arises regarding the verification process. How effectively do they validate the information received from brands through the questionnaire? While relying on brand certifications and self-reported data, Freshlabels lacks a robust independent verification mechanism.

Despite these sustainability-focused marketing efforts, the company's primary focus remains on promotion and sales, as acknowledged in the interview. Ladislav Žižka's statement highlights their ultimate goal of financial success, driving the need for sales and marketing activities. While these efforts may indirectly promote sustainable practices, they also contribute to consumerism, which can conflict with the principles of sustainable marketing. In the topic of used channels, he was also sceptical towards sustainability. Competition pushes them towards similar practices. They cannot afford to abandon certain channels where the competition exists, even though they realize they may not be the most environmentally friendly.

The main surprising conclusion from this interview is the prioritization of quality and trend over sustainability. Ladislav Žižka several times mentioned quality is the priority when choosing a brand they want to collaborate with. True sustainable marketing should prioritize education and offering high-quality, durable products that consumers purchase only when needed. In contrast, Freshlabels' approach often encourages continuous purchasing, although, with an emphasis on long-lasting, high-quality products. This conflict makes it difficult to evaluate Freshlabels' net impact on waste generation.

Overall, Freshlabels demonstrates a willingness to embrace sustainability practices. However, closing the gap between their efforts and a truly comprehensive sustainable approach requires addressing verification challenges and potentially refocusing marketing strategies. By prioritizing education and collaboration, Freshlabels can solidify their position as a leader in the sustainable fashion movement.

2.1.2 Target group interviews

This chapter provides a detailed analysis of the results of the data collected through interviews regarding attitude towards sustainability, the Freshlabels brand, and sustainable marketing.

2.1.2.1 Methodology

The study focused on exploring consumer perceptions and experiences with Freshlabels and their approach to sustainability. A crucial aspect of this study was the selection of participants that represented a varied demographic and a spectrum of experiences with the brand under investigation within the target group. Eight Czech participants were recruited for the study, with careful consideration given to achieving diversity in terms of shopping behaviour and age range (19 – 53). The common factor among all participants was their interest in sustainability and fashion, which automatically categorized them as the target audience of the brand under investigation. Four participants who have never shopped at Freshlabels and four who are already customers were selected.

Qualitative online interviews were chosen as the primary method of data collection due to their flexibility and ability to reach participants across different geographical locations. Each interview lasted approximately 20 minutes, providing a balance between depth of insight and participant engagement. The interviews were conducted via video conferencing platforms, allowing for face-to-face interaction despite physical distance.

To ensure consistency in data collection, a semi-structured interview scenario was developed (see Appendix B). This scenario included open-ended questions designed to gain rich, detailed responses from participants. Topics covered during the interviews included participants' perceptions of sustainability, their knowledge of the brand, their shopping habits, their emphasis on transparency and evaluation of various marketing tactics.

The interviews were recorded for the possibility of transcription later. First, all interviews were transcribed from the recordings to ensure accuracy in capturing participants' responses. Next, the transcripts were translated to English. Then, they were summarized and entered into a table (Appendix B) for clarity and easier comparison of responses.

Data obtained from the qualitative interviews were analysed using combination of thematic and content analysis. Combining these methods allowed for more in depth understanding and evaluation of the responses. It was possible to gain comprehensive view of the data while also providing more specific insights from each response.

2.1.2.2 Presentation of findings

First part of the survey was dedicated to individual attitude towards sustainability. Reflecting participants view on the topic and approach. All respondents have a relatively good overview of sustainability principles. Most of them mentioned the need to mitigate the environmental impact and social responsibility. Both towards the workers in the factories and towards future generations, who may pay for inconsiderate production and waste.

When asked what a company must do to be considered sustainable, the common response was an active approach to sustainability issues, the use of responsibly sourced materials, and fair processes. It was also repeatedly mentioned that in the fashion industry the only truly sustainable practices are considered to be buying from second-hand stores or swapping clothes. Transparency was also a frequently mentioned topic across the questions. Respondents often stated that they would sometimes choose a high-quality product with more available information, even if it may not be 100% environmentally or socially friendly, rather than one that is labelled as sustainable but lacks substantiated information about its production. One respondent had particularly interesting response. He argues when judging corporate claims one can never know how the product is made unless they can see it or touch it, therefore, unless the product is made in a local shop, it is in majority of cases based on trust. Unfortunately, this is largely true, as the veracity of sustainability claims is difficult to verify, which is why greenwashing is so prevalent, as mentioned in previous chapters.

A common concern among respondents was the price of eco conscious brand. To protect the environment, most people therefore choose different approach, more affordable one. They prioritize quality, strive to buy clothes that last a long time, and embrace circularity: most respondents buy or even sell in second-hand stores.

In line with previous responses, the participants emphasized transparency as one of the key consideration points when buying clothing. The majority of respondents stated that they make an effort to trace the origin of their clothing; however, in many cases, it is impossible to verify everything 100%. Additionally, it takes a considerable amount of time and can lead to a sense of regret for not knowing whether one is supporting a responsible brand. This can often cause frustration, even to the point of affecting some respondents' mental health.

A recurring theme emerged from the responses, which was that the customers perceive Freshlabels as more of a design and style clothes retail store rather than one with sustainable fashion. The common understanding was that they sell products mainly of high quality and design which is why the customers use them. They prioritize quality and attractive design when making purchases, assuming that they are acquiring pieces that will last a long time. They believe this approach is more sustainable than buying cheaper clothing of lower quality. The participants mentioned the feeling that Freshlabels rely quite heavily on trendy clothing,

though not to the extent of fast fashion chains. Furthermore, some alluded to the fact the brand cannot be fully sustainable when they support the amount of transport by bringing clothing from other countries rather than supporting local brands.

According to some respondents Freshlabels heavily rely on sustainability marketing without ensuring the brands they sell on their website or in stores are sustainable. After studying their website one participant pointed out the fact that almost every product is labelled as sustainable – it feels like a buzzword and suggests using labels like fair trade, organic cotton which describe the product better and are more transparent. Several other respondents highlighted the issue of product sustainability. They see it as a challenge for essentially any company. Sustainability claims are often difficult to prove and verify, and consumers must rely on the truthfulness of descriptions on company websites. But even there, it is just a description on their website, so there is a certain amount of rhetoric. Some find Freshlabels information about the manufacturing of product they sell not satisfactory, so they check directly at the producer website or other platforms while others do not believe any claims of any brand, therefore they generally do not take them into consideration. On the other hand, some find Freshlabels' product sustainability information useful and in their case credible.

Not all respondents were aware of the Sustainable tag questionnaire prior to the survey. After being introduced to this concept, the reactions were mostly positive. People liked the idea of the initiative. Some mentioned that they would be guided by it in the future. Others said that it was definitely useful, but they would not use it as their only source of information. For some respondents, there was still the question of the trustworthiness of this questionnaire, as it is all based on the claims and answers of individual companies, which can be difficult to verify if someone does not physically visit the factory.

As to the perception of sustainable marketing in the last part of the survey the majority of respondents stated it focuses on real and transparent brand or product promotion. It does not try to deceive customers or wrap the brand in a 'green' package that is not true to its values. However, many did not take into consideration the means that marketing uses and everything that marketers can impact. This is, of course, determined by the factor of the level of education in the industry. Whether in the field of marketing or sustainable practices.

There was the greatest consensus on the use of social media as a very responsible marketing tool. Likewise, blogs and newsletters were also considered to be environmentally friendly, however, considered annoying and not used by most. Generally, the participants focused mainly on the waste each of the medium produces and the impact it has on customers behaviour. In the topic of social media, e-shop, blog, newsletter none of them were aware of the digital footprint.

Spring sales, buy one get one free and similar marketing practises the respondents evaluated as unsustainable, as they promote consumerism and demonstrate that companies do not have adequate pricing strategies. Some, however, admit taking advantage of similar promotions and focus primarily on reducing clothing waste, as already mentioned. Marketing materials and flyers were unanimously identified as the worst practice. They generate completely unnecessary waste, demonstrate that the company is not serious about sustainability, and are also completely useless and none of the respondents likes or uses them.

Video commercials were also evaluated as mostly environmentally friendly. One of the respondents pointed out the link between commercials and greenwashing. However, the production and work behind the commercial was not mentioned in the answers. That is given by the respondents' professional backgrounds, lacking experience in production, led them to overlook the resource and waste production costs involved. In terms of sustainability, all participants preferred physical stores over online shops. They valued the ability to touch and inspect products in person, assess their quality, and gain a better understanding of the company. In contrast, some participants perceived online shops as contributing to higher transportation emissions. Another respondent also mentioned that online shopping can lead to impulse purchases, which goes against sustainability principles.

In conclusion, this study has provided valuable insights into shopping habits of customers and potential customers of Freshlabels. Overall, the participants' responses emphasized the importance of quality products and transparency in marketing. It also revealed a widespread distrust of brands, not just Freshlabels. The scepticism presents a challenge that will be very difficult to overcome. Many people do not trust company claims that are based solely on their word. They want real evidence provided by independent third-party sources. By understanding these perspectives, the company can work towards a different strategy or an evaluation service that would provide unbiased information about their products.

Unfortunately, the respondents did not have sufficient information about specific Freshlabels' marketing campaigns, therefore, further research would be necessary to evaluate the perception.

2.1.3 Analysis and discussion

A concise summary of the key findings regarding brand positioning and target group perception of the brand image can be found in Figure 8. According to Freshlabels' website and information provided in the CEO interview they view themselves as a company which did not start as a sustainable one, nonetheless, is on a trajectory to become one. A discrepancy exists between how the brand presents itself and how customers view it. The brand emphasizes sustainability, quality, and design in their marketing materials, however, the questioned customers stated they shop there mainly because of the quality and style of the products and view it as more of a trendy brand.

Customers may not be fully aware that the brand offers sustainable tag which provides information about the origin of products. However, even when they became familiar with the concept, some were not entirely convinced. Ladislav Žižka mentioned that Freshlabels itself does not have any certifications, other than a sustainable e-shop, but requires them from brands whose clothing it labels as sustainable. However, even so, both potential and regular customers are sceptical about this. The survey indicates it might not be a mistrust regarding to Freshlabels specifically, but the widespread of greenwashing used by many brands which leads to suspicion generally when it comes to clothing.

The brand also aspires to cultivate an image of community brand. They try to enter various communities, for example tourists, runners or other sport enthusiasts through organising, hosting, or collaborating on events. This interesting concept, nonetheless, is not perceived by the customers in the survey. Furthermore, some of the events are private and target only a small group of customers or friends of the brand, therefore these initiatives are not relative to the majority. Moreover, they also participate in organising cultural or music festivals which might be interesting to the general public but is not communicated enough. In general, it can be said that their efforts to integrate into certain communities are not sufficient and reach a small number of people and are not at all reflected in general brand awareness.

The survey suggests a focus on quality, as often there is not enough information available about products and people prefer to spend their money on something high-quality that will last. Which is a more sustainable approach for many than spending money on something with a sustainability label. The results reveal an opportunity to reinforce the brand's message. Given the general distrust of labelling products as sustainable, it would be beneficial for the brand to focus primarily on marketing its products as high-quality and/or to change the narrative around sustainable products and demonstrate their origin in a different way, or to better educate consumers about the concept of the Sustainable tag.

OVERVIEW OF TARGET AUDIENCE PERCEPTION OF THE BRAND VS. BRAND POSITIONING



FRESHLABELS

Sustainable, high quality
and design products

Questionnaire providing
environmental and social impact
information

Focus on community building,
business profit

Collaboration on festivals and
events as main promo

Sustainable operations, recycling
all waste, paperless returns



TARGET GROUP

Trendy, premium products of high
quality

Information about products based solely
on answers of producers, hard to
verificate

Low awareness of the Sustainable tag
and work behind questionnaire

Driving over consumptive behaviour,
selling trends

Low recognition of brand's extra
activities

Figure 8: Overview of target audience perception of the brand vs. brand positioning. (source: Author)

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, this thesis examined the growing importance of sustainable marketing practices that companies can integrate into their operations. By analysing Freshlabels, a well-known fashion brand, we explored how these practices can be implemented and the challenges companies face in building consumer trust. Primarily, a history of sustainability and its definition was described. Subsequently, complex framework of sustainable marketing was introduced showing the aspects which a company must address when aiming for a responsible behaviour. Finally, the findings were compared with Freshlabels' actions in the practical part.

It is complicated to use one definition of sustainability since it became a globally known topic and now it is one of the biggest trends and buzz words used in modern countries. Nonetheless, the main meaning, mostly remains the same. In essence, sustainability is meeting our current needs without harming the ability of future generations to meet their own needs. This means considering environmental protection, economic development, and social equity all at the same time.

Sustainable marketing should address all 3 main aspects of sustainability by driving change within the company. *Can Marketing save the planet?* by Michelle Carvill and Gemma Butler presented a concept of Revisiting the 7 P's through Responsible Sustainable Marketing Lens. It can serve as guide or control for sustainable actions. They suggest environmental changes and initiatives one can make withing all phases: Product, Price, Place, Promotion, People, Process and Physical evidence. It is also a useful tool to follow through analysis of a company's action which was used to assess Freshlabels' endeavours.

Through an interview with CEO Ladislav Žižka and analysis of Freshlabels' website a brand sustainability assessment was conducted. The driving force behind all the brand's actions was the fact that the primary purpose of business is still to make profit. Sustainability plays a role in Freshlabels' behaviours but is not considered to be of equal importance. Even though Freshlabels brand themselves as sustainable and bring great efforts into the sustainable brand image their primary focus is on growth and income equally as any other business. The key indicators of their focus and unsustainable behaviour are the support of consumerism through sales and campaigns, offering trendy clothing from foreign companies and large number of brands in their portfolio which is continuously growing.

On the other hand, they also practice many commendable ways to mitigate their environmental and social impact including Sustainable tag questionnaire which indicates sustainability level of their products, paperless returns, Loop program for unused or damaged clothes, recycled packaging and more. They are taking a smart approach by using small steps to reduce their impact on the planet and society. By offering a unique service called the Sustainable tag and

managing their waste responsible they are already setting an example for other brands, not only in the fashion industry.

Their impact and brand image were also evaluated by a qualitative interviews with respondents from target group. The participants were broadly sceptical towards green practises. However, this attitude possibly represented feelings towards fashion industry. Due to the rampant greenwashing, they encounter, people are sceptical of sustainability claims and demand hard evidence about a company's operations and processes before considering it sustainable. This presents a significant challenge for any brand in fashion industry. The Sustainable tag was not enough for many and would welcome more evidence-based information regarding the products. Otherwise, most respondents view Freshlabels as a responsible company where they can find products of high – quality and great design. Unfortunately, none of the respondents were aware about the other activities Freshlabels pursuits such as collaborations on festivals, educating or organising sports events. This offers a great potential for Freshlabels to shift their communication and inform more about their endeavours.

Predominantly, when talking about sustainability of a business, the primary focus of companies and customer is mainly the sustainability of the product, hardly other aspects of marketing. The term sustainable marketing is not widely known, and it is still a new concept that has a huge potential to change functioning of many industries.

The right marketer has a potential to change so many aspects of a company principles. The issues mainly lay on the principles of the company and individual approach of the executives. Generally, it is easier to effect sustainable practises in smaller local company, however, especially in big corporations small steady changes in the behaviour and practises can have a huge impact on the social and natural environment. Moreover, it is not only the question of the effect on the nature it is becoming necessary business strategy as more consumers and employees demand responsible behaviour of the companies.

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APPENDICES

APPENDIX A: Interview with Freshlabels CEO Ladislav Žižka

- What led you to adopt sustainable practices and establish a sustainable brand? What is your relationship with sustainability? What is Freshlabels' philosophy?

L.Ž.: It's about conviction; we believe we can do what others do but with lower impact and considering the weight of our surroundings. Part of our business concept is to adhere to certain practices. We don't aim to be saviours; business organizations must make a profit, and that remains a priority.

- Should sustainability be the standard?

L.Ž.: It would be difficult – it's a vicious circle. Sustainable production is costly – products are more expensive – they don't sell in large quantities – they cannot be made cheaper. Technologies for sustainable production cannot be acquired cheaply, so it remains a premium product and cannot be standard.

- How would you describe your company's overall sustainability strategy?

L.Ž.: Freshlabels doesn't produce anything on its own. We are resellers. We discover brands with quality products. We vouch for these brands and ensure customer service. The goal is to provide options for the customers.

1. Quality – people buy more expensive products, but they last longer. They think more about their purchases (not impulsive buys).
2. Production – offering international well-known or small local brands that are somehow interesting, unique (e.g., using waste from their industry for production - shirts made from old T-shirts).
3. Research – a team that seeks out brands. Participation in trade shows (SEED Berlin, Paris, Copenhagen).
4. Questionnaire – ongoing check <https://www.freshlabels.cz/udrzitelnost-kriteria/> Thousand hours of work, constantly improving, a service that is unmatched - providing end-users with certainty.

- Do you implement sustainable principles in your marketing? What does sustainable marketing mean to you?

L.Ž.: It goes hand in hand - we build our brand on giving space to brands that do something right. Fundamentally, we use the same practices as all other brands. We can't afford not to do them. Competition will be there if we aren't. The competitive environment still exists, and the goal of any business is to make money. Goods must be sold.

At the same time, we try to do something different: our main marketing move is events – usually linked to presenting a new brand/collection/material. Also, discussions, education at universities, which also support brands plus education about their approach to business.

Primarily, we focus on community building. We try to connect with individual institutions/communities – hiking, outdoor, running, cycling, urban gardens. When we connect with someone, we figure out how to connect them with the brand and the community within the sport.

Loop program – old items can be returned: <https://www.freshlabels.cz/en/loop/>.

Promoting a brand could look like this: agreement with the brand to organise joint event. One month prior to the event we boost social media, newsletter, influencers, then at the time of the event the marketing is at a peak and then we reuse it for another month or so.

Main channels are social networks, influencers. The stores are a statement - sustainable store - design - marketing draw. They function as a lure in themselves. Secondary channels - banners, radio.

- How do you start collaborations with brands?

L.Ž.: Smaller brands see us as a platform and reach out to us themselves. We have a research team that seeks out brands. We participate in trade fairs across Europe, where we get inspiration (SEED Berlin, Paris, Copenhagen).

- Are there any certificates or standards that your company complies with in sustainability? Or that you eventually want to achieve? Do you have any awards?

L.Ž.: There are many certificates, most of them for product manufacturers. As a retailer, reseller, we primarily focus on ensuring our suppliers have certificates. See the last step of our questionnaire here <https://www.freshlabels.cz/udrzitelnost-kriteria/>.

More information, but definitely not all, about various certificates can be found here <https://www.freshlabels.cz/slovník-pojmu/>.

We have primarily business awards, such as being listed in Heureka Sustainable Shop. Everything we do within sustainability can be seen here <https://www.freshlabels.cz/udrzitelnost/>.

- How do you gather feedback from customers regarding your initiatives?

L.Ž.: Personal interviews, social networks, Customer hotline, Subjective assessment based on interest in the following action.

- What key performance indicators or metrics does your company use to measure sustainability and campaign success? Can you share them?

L.Ž.: You're asking about two completely different things. We are not ECO activists = our campaigns are not measured by sustainability indicators.

We measure sustainability by the number of brands we offer in our portfolio. Currently, it's 70% = 7 out of 10 brands currently have a sustainable tag from us. However, our goal is not to reach 100%. We primarily offer quality and design pieces. In terms of sustainability, we try to have the largest share, but the brand must always meet the first two elements, i.e., quality and design.

Campaigns are then measured by traditional metrics. Brand campaigns based on the number of people reached, brand awareness, and online search increase. Performance campaigns based on order volume and return on investment.

To be able to focus on our main pillars of discovering quality and design brands from around the world, we must first do good business. Otherwise, nothing, not even sustainability.

APPENDIX B: Sustainability awareness and brand recognition survey results

	#1	#2	#3	#4
demographics	28 years, female, architect, editor	31 years, female, lawyer	30 years, female	32 years, male, engineer
What does sustainability mean to you?	Thinking, locality, modesty	Minimalism, non-waste, stopping consumerism, maximal utilization, circulation, not burdening future generations, the environment, the planet	It's cheaper for one, and it's also more environmentally friendly. I associate that word with sustainability, with it being good for the planet. Whether it's fashion or furniture, for example, when we were furnishing our apartment, or even electronic products like computers and everything else. I always try to get things second-hand.	Sustainability for me is more of a lifestyle, even though I'm not an orthodox environmentalist. But I think that when things are sustainable, they are also high quality, durable and less environmentally demanding.
Why is it important for you?	I see it as one of the small beginnings to change people's behavior on the planet, to prevent consumption, etc.	For the salvation of the planet and preservation of resources for future generations.	When I was around 13 y.o., I stopped eating meat and became a vegetarian. I started watching documentaries about meat production. One of them was about how milk is made, and it made me really unhappy. Now, sustainability is just a part of my life. I see it as my responsibility.	I think about where all the waste goes, especially clothes. In some places, like Morocco, they have a big problem with this because they just burn it on the streets and don't recycle it.
What does a business need to fulfill for you to consider it sustainable? What is most important to you?	I'm not from the field, so I don't understand the specific requirements for companies to be sustainable. However, for me, it's the brand philosophy, the quality of materials, the place of production, and ultimately the price—cheap items, I believe, will never be sustainable.	It must indicate its impact not only on the environment, but also on labor forces, resources, and strive to do so as effectively as possible. I care mainly about the workforce and its impact on the environment.	It's really hard because everyone is greenwashing so much, so it's difficult to choose a brand that's truly eco-friendly or sustainable. Most of the time, it's just small companies that are naturally expensive, which makes it hard for me as a student to afford their products. But that's something they should have. What's important to me is when they list the people who make the products, where they're made, and where the materials come from. It shouldn't just say "100% recycled plastic bottles," but also provide links to various projects. Patagonia comes to mind as a company that does this well. They organize volunteer beach cleanups and other initiatives. In today's world, it's also important who wears the brand and that I see people wearing it for a long time and that it holds up well. I see friends or influencers wearing the same piece for a long time and it still looks good.	Ideally, I envision a sustainable business as one that does not have all of its production in a place like Vietnam or other developing countries, and that uses products made from either recycled or natural materials.
What is sustainable fashion? What do you do to dress sustainably?	I shop at thrift stores, Vinted, or at stores with higher-quality brands, and I carefully consider whether I need something.	Sustainable fashion is circular and minimalist fashion. I shop at second-hand stores, on Vinted (where I also sell), I buy much less than before, I don't shop at some stores (fast fashion) at all anymore, within my family, we borrow items, I aim to achieve a minimalist wardrobe and try to maximize the use of what I already have at home. Anything I don't wear, I either sell or donate to charity. I only throw away clothing that is truly unusable and damaged."	It's still really trendy to be eco-friendly, but I've realized that it's not always practical for me to go all out. Instead of buying jeans that are handmade in the Czech Republic by designers and made from recycled denim or with reduced water usage, I prefer to focus on thrift stores, it's like my replacement for going to the mall. We also swap clothes with each other to refresh our wardrobes without throwing anything away.	Try to buy from brands that are known for making things from recycled materials or natural fibers. I also don't buy as much clothing. I buy Patagonia, because I feel they do a good job in providing information and the products are durable and I can wear them for a long time.
What role does transparency play for you when purchasing clothing? Where do you find out whether a brand is sustainable or if it's greenwashing?	Honestly, I'm a bit lost in this, and I myself would be interested in how to recognize this. I realize that there is a certain amount of greenwashing even with the "best" brands	Transparency in clothing purchases is important to me. I utilize information from the internet, social media, Netflix documentaries, information from my daughters, podcasts like Natalia Pažická's. I usually find out if a brand is sustainable from their website or by googling.	When I do buy clothes online, I check out the brand's website to see what they say about their sustainability practices. Then I look at two other websites that rate the sustainability of different brands on a scale. They compare how much waste each company produces, and I can then see how truthful the brand's claims are. It's often not what they make it out to be. For my mental health, I've decided to occasionally put sustainability aside and choose a brand and product that I love and will wear until it falls apart, even though I know it's not the best for the planet.	Patagonia for example organise many workshops, lectures etc. Where they show how they manufacture vs. The problems of mass manufacturing. I usually check brand's website and social media.

Do you know the brand Freshlabels?	Yes	Yes	yes	Yes
Have you ever shopped there? Why? Why not?	Yes. I like their clothing. I used to see them as a store that brings interesting brands and pieces to Czechia that couldn't be found elsewhere. But now I see them as somewhat mainstream, and they've exceeded their own measure	I've shopped there several times, mostly online, based on my daughters' recommendation. However, I had a negative experience with an expensive backpack I bought; it broke after just a few months. The warranty process was frustrating, with poor communication and rude treatment in-store. Despite eventually receiving a replacement, I was disappointed with the overall service. While the backpack I received as a replacement is holding up well, the ordeal has left me hesitant to support the brand further.	I bought some thermoses, books, and I think a backpack and shoes there. They have exactly the brands I like, which I consider sustainable. I know that some of the things I bought there are not sustainable, but I just like them more than the eco-friendly ones.	They do not sell billions of products, just a few clothing of high quality. I purchased the product mainly because of style rather than sustainability.
Which slogan (associations) do you associate with Freshlabels? Design/Quality/Sustainability/Trend	Hipster, trend, fashion	Sustainability, design.	Design, trend, mainstream. Lot of people go there just because it is cool and popular. Quality - the items I have lasted over several years, I use them often and they are still in very good conditions.	design, high quality. Sustainability not really.
Is Freshlabels sustainable brand? Why? How do they prove it?	I can't answer that, I've never looked at Freshlabels for sustainability. I usually look at the specific brand's websites that I want to buy. But even there, it's just a description on their website, so there's a certain amount of rhetoric. I think you can not be fully sustainable if you support the amount of transport Freshlabels does. The product are not local.	I would say they are. They provide information about the products and materials which I find convenient.	Again for me the quality is important and they deliver it. Even the cashier when I was there said not everything is 100% sustainable.	50:50. Not all products are sustainable, I rather check at the product manufacturer, I do not see Freshlabels as source for sustainabel brands.
Does Freshlabels support consumism? How?	To some extent, probably yes. Actually, I wonder how many pieces of clothing they order and how much is left over. Or if they know their sales and mostly sell out.	I felt they were endorsing consumerism, prioritizing quantity over quality. In Nila, I have a completely different feeling; sustainability truly matters there. However, I don't get that feeling at Freshlabels. Perhaps on their e-shop, but not in their physical store.	Things like spring sail, various collection throughout year etc. support consumism, which they also do.	Definitely, because it is store like any other, meaning they need to make money.
Do you know what is Freshlabels sustainable tag? Have you used it? Would you consider using it in the future? Is it useful?	No, but I will look into it.	I'm familiar with the sustainable tag... assessing various criteria of sustainable production... I'm not sure if they have to meet all or just certain criteria to be called sustainable. That's not clear to me. Useful, yes. Definitely for the future.	I didn't know the have anything like it and I find it really cool and transparent, even for people who do not have broad knowledge of the production cycle, for me included.	I haven't heard about it. I think it might be useful for people. But I choose what I buy mostly based on quality and style so I can wear it for a long time.

How would you define sustainable marketing?	The media and ways which marketers use and if how it sells the sustainable concepts.	Set of activities to promote information about sustainability? I consider it important as part of general awareness, educating people, explaining various concepts, and the significance itself. I find it important for individual brands."	The brand acknowledges how its campaigns affect environment and their impact.	I think it is selling products branded as sustainable.
Evaluate how much are these marketing practises sustainable and why do you think that?				
1 - SUSTAINABLE 5 - UNSUSTAINABLE				
use of social media	3 - sustainable, but a tool of consumption. So, ultimately not really.	1	1 - Works very well with younger generation, specifically influencer marketing. It is important to select influencers who share the same value. I also find inspiration in influencers and the products they use. And it also affects me when I see the collaboration is not genuine.	1 - No waste created or materials used.
newsletter	4 - annoying, urging people to consume	3 - I don't read newsletters by default, and I find them bothersome. Moreover, they often end up in spam or promotional folders.	2 - It can have big impact. For me personally it is "unsubscribe" from everything so it does not push me towards buying products I do not need.	3 - not useful really
blog	1 - YES! For me, the best option	3	2	1
billboards	1 - sustainable yes	4	4	5 - advertising clutter, not sustainable
posters, flyers	3 - paper waste, but compared to packaging for shipping parcels, it's okay		5 - flyers are unuseful and create waste	5 - nobody looks at it and it is just wasted paper
organising events	4 - unsustainable, but if it has some impact, like educational, then why not	1 - I would say but I have never been to a promo event.	3 - It really depend on the environment, suppliers etc.	3 - depends on the individual event
video commercial	3 - Very expensive matter. It probably depends, I can't say so generally	1	3	1 - pretty much like social media
gift products (pens, notebooks, bottle openers etc.)	5 - Junk	5	5 - Nobody uses it, its just waste.	5
discounts, sales 1+1...	2 - actually maybe yes, at least more is sold	2	5	3 - supports consummism, but it is great
e-shop	4 - depends on the type and scale. But because of transportation, probably not	1	3	4 - not really sustainable, pushes to buy more than what we need
physical store	1 - yes! everything in one place, no transportation, no extra money	1	1 - I prefer this. I get more information and better feeling of the product. But for small businesses it is usually too expensive.	1 - I prefer it.

	#5	#6	#7	#8
demographics	23 years, male, student, chemist	19 years, male, high school student	24 years, female, student of ecological entrepreneurship	43 years, male, graphic designer
What does sustainability mean to you?	Efforts to push corporations towards more sustainable resource management, production, etc.	The production of a product from renewable sources, using a manufacturing process that minimally impacts nature, with an emphasis on quality.	Sustainability for me means that a person tries to minimize the impacts of their everyday, but also business activities on the functioning of the world, mainly from a social and environmental perspective. Sustainability for me represents a mindset that focuses on preserving resources for future generations, so that they can live and operate on Earth just like generations before them.	For me, it means sustaining the planet, possessions, and the people around me in a state that's optimal for them in the long run. So, if I were to translate that into a sustainable product, it would be the highest quality product (to keep people happy that they have a good thing) made by happy individuals who are fairly valued for their work, using quality materials, all in a manner that doesn't harm the planet and doesn't violate any common moral values (like child labor).
Why is it important for you?	To avoid burning out, for our future, survival on this planet.	For the sake of nature and waste production limitation.	It is important mainly from the perspective of the climate crisis we are facing. It is necessary to reassess how we as a society have approached functioning on Earth so far and how to change it to avoid irreversible consequences	Because without it, or at least without attempting to get as close to it as possible, people will be unhappy, and the planet will be in an increasingly worse state.
What does a business need to fulfill for you to consider it sustainable? What is most important to you?	I have to see it with my own eyes (local seamstress). I don't trust corporations and brands.	Quality materials, fair processes, business set up with appropriate pricing for both the customer and the producer.	For me to consider a business sustainable, it must have this sustainable "mindset" built into its functioning, at the core of the company/organization. It must not only be guided by it superficially; all its missions, visions, strategic decisions, and activities must fully align with and adhere to sustainability principles. In practice, organizations should align themselves with the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), which need to be achieved by 2030 and encompass several specific objectives aimed at mitigating the climate crisis. The most important aspect for me is probably transparency and the commitment of companies, even if they may not be performing perfectly yet, but demonstrate visible efforts to transform their operations and communicate this to their stakeholders.	When purchasing products, I don't specifically seek out information on companies' sustainability efforts. However, I try to buy quality products from manufacturers that I trust aren't doing anything too terrible. The most important thing for me is probably knowing that I'm not being deceived and being aware of what I'm buying and under what conditions. For example, I really dislike the store TEMU, which aggressively lowers prices to attract as many people as possible to their app, where they extract data that is far more important to them than the profit from selling a single stupid backpack. Most people don't even think about this. I understand that some products are hard to produce and might have a negative impact on the planet, but it bothers me when companies try to hide that.
What is sustainable fashion? What do you do to dress sustainably?	Basically just thrift stores, I don't buy from so-called sustainable stores.	The key for me is high-quality renewable material, long-lasting.	Sustainable fashion to me means achieving a balance between two key elements: social and environmental. It should involve fair employment practices and not harm nature through pollution or depletion of resources. Quality craftsmanship is essential for longevity, and ideally, garments should be made from recyclable materials. Personally, I prioritize second-hand shopping, upcycling, and platforms like Vinted to reduce waste. When buying new, I look for brands that prioritize sustainability and hold relevant certifications. I aim for a versatile wardrobe of quality pieces that can be mixed and matched to avoid impulsive purchases.	Sustainable fashion, for me, is the kind that I don't discard after a few wears, whether it's because the product is worn out or because I no longer like it. It's about recycling, either by someone else buying it from a thrift store or by repurposing it into something new. I buy quality clothes that I expect to last several seasons, and I'm willing to pay extra for that. I wear things until they're worn out and beyond. A small hole in a shirt isn't a reason for me to throw it away; I wear shoes until they wear me out. Occasionally, I shop at thrift stores. When a shirt is really worn out, I tear it up and use it as a rag. I mainly buy things that I need. I don't buy many things just because I like them, so I don't have much, and I don't own anything that I wouldn't wear (at least at home).
What role does transparency play for you when purchasing clothing? Where do you find out whether a brand is sustainable or if it's greenwashing?	I don't believe it, everything is to some extent greenwashing. Those claims can't be verified in any way.	It pisses me off when it's an obvious lie, but then again, I don't really care that much. I check the label and the place of manufacture.	Transparency is key in the fashion industry. Brands should be honest about their sustainability efforts rather than hiding behind green campaigns. I rely on online resources like the Fashion Transparency Index and Good On You, a non-profit organization, to assess a brand's commitment to sustainability.	Transparency is important to me, but I don't actively seek it out. However, it would bother me if I started looking into it and found out that the brand was being dishonest.
Do you know the brand FreshLabels?	No.	No.	No.	I have heard about it but never looked at it.
Have you ever shopped there? Why? Why not?	No, never heard of it.	No - high price, I'd rather buy cheaper shirts of the same quality and wear them longer - greater sustainability.	I've heard about FreshLabels, probably because in the past, this store gave me the impression of being a sustainable brand. It seemed to me as more of an eco-friendly and as among others .	Not yet
Which slogan (associations) do you associate with FreshLabels? Design/Quality/Sustainability/Trend	It is rarely as good as it looks.	Judging by the website - sustainability, trend.	Seems like all the aspects you listed. It appears that FreshLabels also markets itself as a sustainable brand, but in reality, it often prioritizes trends and design, which are not necessarily synonymous with sustainability. The items are probably of good quality; my partner bought about three things there, and they've held up so far. Also, it's worth mentioning that it's expensive.	quality brands, style
Is FreshLabels a sustainable brand? Why? How do they prove it?	Selling anything is from the principle of things unsustainable.	Yes - evidence, lifetime warranty guarantees - focus on quality.	Their image is that of a sustainable brand. In the past, I praised them for it, but as I educated myself on the topic, I realized they heavily rely on sustainability without ensuring the brands they sell on their website or in stores are actually sustainable. At their website, almost every product is labeled as sustainable - it feels like a buzzword. I prefer labels like fair trade, organic cotton - they tell me more and are more transparent in my opinion.	Because they seek out brands that are sustainable and sell their products. I see them as places where I could go and count on not supporting any dirt.
Does FreshLabels support consumerism? How?	Yes. You can not consume sustainability.	Yes. They sell trendy and useless stuff.	They rely quite heavily on trendy clothing, though not to the extent of fast fashion chains. But for me, it still evokes consumerism. The brand itself suggests that FreshLabels' clothing is worn by cool people, and I should want it too - which, to me, is consumerism.	Anyone who sells something supports it at some level.
Do you know what is FreshLabels sustainable tag? Have you used it? Would you consider using it in the future? Is it useful?	Pinkie promise? On what basis is that? It can't be verified, independent audits are shady, greenwashing.	No, but I see it as great marketing move.	Overall, it's a likeable initiative, providing more information in a clear, concise, and comprehensive manner - though I hope it aligns with reality. In the future, I'd use it, but probably not as the sole source of information.	I find it useful but I personally would not use it.
How would you define sustainable marketing?	Ozymorss? That doesn't exist, right? The only truly sustainable marketing is word of mouth.	Balancing sales, profit and fairness.	Sustainable marketing focuses on real and transparent brand/product promotion. It doesn't try to deceive customers or wrap the brand in a 'green' package that's not true to its values.	I would define it the same way as sustainability - it's communication that doesn't screw anyone over - neither people, nor the planet, nor the environment. It doesn't spoil the appearance of cities and so on.
Evaluate how much are these marketing practises sustainable and why do you think that? 1-SUSTAINABLE 5- UNSUSTAINABLE				
use of social media	1	1 - Social media is used by an extreme number of people and doesn't utilize any industrial production in itself.	2 - It depends on whether it's trustworthy; then I always verify the information myself anyway.	1 - If I'm not targeting children or people in financial crisis with a product that is approaching or is outright gambling. In the case of fashion, I can't think of how socks could be unsustainable.
newsletter	1 - At least it doesn't produce waste	1 - Because it doesn't use any natural resources, but nowadays, I think it's already relatively inefficient and people view them negatively because they seem very artificial and impersonal	5 - I do not like it nor use it.	1 - but it is annoying
blog		1 - it doesn't use any industrial resources and is a medium that I would imagine is primarily consumed by people interested in sustainable goods.	5 - I do not like it nor use it.	1
billboards	5 - Waste and light pollution in the city.	5 - their construction alone consumes natural resources and gives people the impression of consumerist sales, which somewhat contradicts sustainable marketing.	5 - I do not notice it anymore and it creates waste	4 - "There are good billboards that enrich their surroundings, but it would still be better if there were no billboards at all, so I'm not a fan."
posters, flyers	5	5 - unnecessary paper production, which often, for durability, is wax-coated - therefore, less recyclable.	5 - lot of waste and not trustworthy	3 - "Distributing flyers on the street is just a waste of paper in my opinion. Posters are fine though."
organising events	3	1 - Sustainable - it's inherently sustainable. It's done in person, which could help convey credibility.	2 - Being able to see firsthand, ask questions, learn something new, and interact with people makes it genuine and enjoyable. In my opinion, word-of-mouth works best in these situations.	1 - Really cool, but depends on the place and activities
video commercial	2	1 - if done in a style that doesn't come off too corporate. It's sustainable for similar reasons as marketing on social media.	3 - I usually connect it with big brands which usually use greenwashing	1
gift products (pens, notebooks, bottle openers etc.)	5	5 - some of them have quite energy-intensive production and can't even be reused often (such as promotional pens with non-replaceable ink).	5 - oldschool, waste, pollution, not sustainable at all	1
discounts, sales 1+1...	5	5 - They give people the impression of consumerist sales, where companies try to push as much of their goods onto customers as possible, even if they don't need them. This undermines the purpose of sustainable sales.	4 - It persuades a lot of people to impulsive buys, but if you are smart about it, you can save money.	5
e-shop	3 - I don't know what happens with the product when I return it. Is it thrown away?	4 - Rather less sustainable - they use maritime (and other) transportation, which is environmentally unfriendly.	4 - Sounds great, but the logistics involve emissions. Ordering a lot just for testing purposes isn't ideal. It requires thoughtful consideration.	1
physical store	3	2 - Many people prefer them more. They tend to be harder to deceive when it comes to materials, for example, because they can physically verify them.	1 - the best, you can touch and feel the product	1